

# **Vic Cicconetti — This Is Your Life**

**A Tribute on His 80th Birthday**

The Cicconetti Family

2026-03-01

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# Dedication

*For Dad — veteran, educator, entrepreneur, family man.*

*From Bayonne to Vietnam, from the classroom to the family table, yours has been a life of service, love, and laughter. This book is our way of saying what you sign every email:*

Love, Your Family

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**March 2026** — Eighty years. A life that stretches from the streets of Bayonne to the skies over Vietnam, from the hallways of New Jersey’s public schools to the warmth of a family dinner table. This is the story of Victor R. Cicconetti — veteran, educator, entrepreneur, community leader, husband, father, and grandfather. A man whose life truly is, as one newspaper described it, “an American story.”

## **Part I**

# **Part I: Two Families**

# 1 Two Families, One City

*In the early 1900s, two families left southern Italy — one from the mountains of Abruzzo, one from the hills of Campania. They crossed the Atlantic, passed through Ellis Island, and landed in the same small city on the New Jersey waterfront. They didn't know each other yet. But their grandchildren would marry, and this story would begin.*

## **i** Soundtrack: Bayonne Doo-Wop & The Crooners (1950s–early '60s)

Vic grew up in Bayonne in the 1950s G — fifteen minutes from Newark, the doo-wop capital of the world. This is what was coming out of every transistor radio, corner candy store, and church dance in his neighborhood:

**Doo-Wop (the sound of Bayonne)** — *click any song to play*

- [Dion & The Belmonts — “A Teenager in Love”](#) / [Dion — “Runaround Sue”](#)
- [The Four Seasons — “Sherry”](#) / [The Four Seasons — “Big Girls Don’t Cry”](#) (*Frankie Valli = Jersey royalty*)
- [The Drifters — “Under the Boardwalk”](#) (*the Jersey Shore anthem*)
- [The Flamingos — “I Only Have Eyes for You”](#)
- [The Platters — “The Great Pretender”](#) / [The Platters — “Smoke Gets in Your Eyes”](#)
- [Frankie Lymon & The Teenagers — “Why Do Fools Fall in Love”](#)
- [Danny & The Juniors — “At the Hop”](#)
- [The Del-Vikings — “Come Go with Me”](#)

## **The Italian-American Crooners (what the parents played)**

- [Dean Martin — “That’s Amore”](#) / [Dean Martin — “Volare”](#)
- [Frank Sinatra — “Fly Me to the Moon”](#) / [Frank Sinatra — “I’ve Got You Under My Skin”](#)
- [Perry Como — “Magic Moments”](#) / [Perry Como — “Catch a Falling Star”](#)
- [Connie Francis — “Who’s Sorry Now”](#) (*she’s from Newark!*)
- [Louis Prima — “Just a Gigolo”](#) / [Louis Prima — “Buona Sera”](#)
- [Bobby Darin — “Beyond the Sea”](#) / [Bobby Darin — “Mack the Knife”](#)

*What did Grandma Eleanor play in the kitchen? What songs does Dad hum when he smells Sunday sauce? [Suggest a song →](#) — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

## **i** Photo Gallery (17 photos)

## **i** The World Vic Was Born Into (1946)

**Consider what a Bayonne household looked like the year Victor Cicconetti was born:**

The family had a **rotary telephone** — one, on the wall, shared by the whole house. Long distance cost real money, so you kept it short. The **radio** was the center of entertainment: Jack Benny, The

Shadow, the evening news. If the family had a **television** at all, it arrived around 1948–50 — a small screen, black and white, three channels if you were lucky, and you adjusted the rabbit ears by hand. The **icebox** was transitioning to an electric refrigerator. Clothes went through a **wringer washer** — no dryer, they hung on the line. Dad drove a car with a manual choke, no seatbelts, no power steering. Mom cooked on a gas stove and preserved food by canning.

There was no air conditioning. No microwave. No answering machine. No calculator — you did math by hand or with a slide rule. A “computer” was a room-sized machine at a university. The ballpoint pen had just been invented. Frozen dinners didn’t exist yet. Neither did the interstate highway system, the polio vaccine, or rock and roll.

**This is the world Victor was born into.** By the time he turns 80, he will have lived through:

- **Rotary phone** → **smartphone** (1946 → now)
- **Three TV channels** → **500 channels** → **streaming** (1950 → 1990 → 2015)
- **Slide rule** → **pocket calculator** → **laptop** → **AI** (1946 → 1972 → 1990 → 2023)
- **Vinyl records** → **8-track** → **cassette** → **CD** → **MP3** → **Spotify** (every format, in order)
- **Handwritten letters** → **email** → **text** → **FaceTime** (the entire arc of communication)
- **No commercial flights** → **moon landing** → **Space Shuttle** → **Mars rovers** (1946 → 1969 → 1981 → 2021)

No generation in human history witnessed more technological change in a single lifetime than the one born in the mid-1940s. Vic didn’t just watch it happen — he embraced it. He was the teacher who wrote grants for Commodore computers when other educators thought it was a fad. He was the dad who had a VIC-20 in the house in 1982. He was the man who, at 79, forwards emails from his desktop and uses his phone to stay in touch with grandchildren spread across the country.

The distance from a Bayonne icebox to a smartphone in your pocket — that’s one lifetime. That’s *his* lifetime.

## 1.1 The Great Departure

### **i** The Bigger Picture: Why 4 Million Italians Left

**The wide lens:** Between 1880 and 1924, over **four million Italians** emigrated to the United States — the largest single-nationality migration in American history. They were overwhelmingly from the *Mezzogiorno* (the south): Campania, Calabria, Sicily, Abruzzo, Puglia. Italy had unified in 1861, but unification made things worse for the south. Northern industrialists taxed southern agriculture to fund northern factories. Inheritance laws divided farms into smaller and smaller plots until a family couldn’t feed itself on what it owned.

**Push factors:** Poverty. Malaria. Cholera. Earthquakes (Messina, 1908: 75,000 dead). A feudal land system that hadn’t changed in centuries. The *contadini* (peasant farmers) had no path forward.

**Pull factors:** American industry needed labor. Steel mills, coal mines, railroads, oil refineries, garment factories — all of it demanded bodies willing to work for wages that, while pitiful by American standards, dwarfed anything available in a stone village in the Apennines. Letters home from relatives already in America — the *lettere di richiamo* — described a world where work was hard but food was plentiful and a man could own a house.

**The numbers:** In peak years (1900–1914), over 200,000 southern Italians arrived annually at Ellis Island. The flow was so enormous that entire villages depopulated. Collepietro — the Cicconetti homeland — has fewer than 200 residents today.

## **i** The Journey: Steerage Class to Ellis Island

### **The middle lens — what the crossing actually looked like:**

The journey began with a walk. From mountain villages like Collepietro, families traveled by mule or on foot to the nearest rail station, then by train to **Naples** — the great embarkation port for southern Italians. There, emigration agents processed their paperwork and sold them passage.

**The ship:** Steerage class. The cheapest tickets (roughly \$30 — about \$1,000 today). Passengers were packed below the waterline in open compartments with tiered metal bunks, no ventilation, and one toilet per hundred people. The crossing took **12 to 17 days**. Seasickness was universal. Many had never seen the ocean before boarding.

**Ellis Island:** The Statue of Liberty appeared first — most immigrants saw her from the deck of the ship, crowded against the railing. Then the ferry to Ellis Island. Then the **Great Hall**: a vast, echoing room where thousands waited in metal-railed lines, clutching their documents.

The inspection had three stages:

1. **Medical exam** — Doctors watched immigrants climb the stairs to the Great Hall, looking for limps, labored breathing, signs of disease. The dreaded “**buttonhook men**” used a small hook to flip back eyelids, checking for trachoma (an eye disease that meant automatic deportation). A chalk mark on your coat — **X** for mental deficiency, **H** for heart, **L** for limp — sent you to a detention room.
2. **Legal inspection** — An officer asked 29 questions: name, age, occupation, final destination, how much money you carried (you needed at least \$25), whether anyone was meeting you, whether you’d ever been in prison. Interpreters translated. The whole interview lasted about two minutes.
3. **The Staircase of Separation** — Three aisles. Left: New York. Center: detained for further review. Right: New Jersey ferry. Families who’d survived the crossing together could be separated here in an instant.

**The success rate:** About **98%** of immigrants who reached Ellis Island were admitted. But that 2% rejection rate — roughly 250,000 people between 1892 and 1924 — meant that every person in that line knew it could happen to them. Ellis Island’s Italian nickname was *L’Isola delle Lacrime* — **the Island of Tears**.

## **i** US Immigration Policy: The Door Opens, Then Closes

### **The policy lens:**

- **1882:** First federal immigration law. Barred “lunatics, idiots, and persons likely to become a public charge.”
- **1892:** Ellis Island opens as the federal immigration station. Before this, states ran their own processing (Castle Garden in Manhattan handled New York).
- **1907:** Peak year — **1.25 million immigrants** processed through Ellis Island. Over 100 nationalities. The building was designed for 500,000.
- **1917:** Literacy test required. Immigrants had to read 30–40 words in their native language. This hit southern Italians hard — many were illiterate.
- **1921:** Emergency Quota Act. First numerical limit on immigration. Capped each nationality at 3% of its 1910 Census population in the US.
- **1924:** Johnson-Reed Act. **Slashed quotas to 2% of the 1890 Census** — deliberately targeting southern and eastern Europeans. Italian immigration dropped from 200,000/year to

under 4,000. The door slammed shut.

The Cicconettis and the Chiarolanzas made it through before the door closed. Had they waited a decade, this story would never have happened.

## 1.2 From Italy to Bayonne

### The Cicconettis

**Origin:** Collepietro, Province of L'Aquila, Abruzzo — a stone village perched at 2,785 feet in the Apennine Mountains, fewer than 200 inhabitants even today.

**The name:** Cicconetti derives from *Franciscus* (“a free man”) through Italian diminutives: Francesco → Cicco → Cicconetti — “little Cicco.” Documented in Collepietro since at least **1778**, when **Camillo Giovanni Cicconetti** married Maria Consiglia Iannarelli.

**The pronunciation — and the war over it:** In Italian, Cicconetti is pronounced with a hard *ch*: “**Chee-ko-NET-tee.**” That’s how the old country said it. That’s how part of the family still says it. But Vic was adamant: the name gets the **Americanized soft C** — “**Sih-ko-NET-tee.**”

It wasn’t vanity. It was survival. Growing up in Bayonne, a kid with a name that started with “Chick-” was a sitting duck. “*Hey, Chicken Head, get over here!*” — the playground taunts that Italian-American kids absorbed like body blows. Every strange surname was ammunition. Every rolled R was a target. The children of immigrants learned fast: you either Americanize or you fight every single day.

Vic chose to Americanize. The soft C was a declaration: *I am from here. This is my country. Say my name the way I tell you to say it.* It was the same instinct that drove the whole immigrant project — don’t just arrive, *belong*. Don’t just survive, *assimilate*. And if the old-country pronunciation has to bend to make that happen, then it bends.

To this day, the family is split. Some Cicconettis use the Italian pronunciation. Some use Vic’s Americanized version. It’s a tiny civil war that plays out every time someone new asks, “How do you say your last name?” — and the answer depends on which branch you’re talking to.

**Why they left:** Between 1880 and 1920, half a million Abruzzesi left Italy. The soil was thin, the winters harsh, inheritance laws fragmented the land. Young men traveled down from the mountains to Naples, boarded steamships, crossed the Atlantic in steerage, and passed through Ellis Island.

**Where they landed:** Bayonne, New Jersey — a city of oil refineries and shipyards on a narrow peninsula jutting into New York Harbor. By 1920, Italians constituted over 20% of the population. The Cicconettis settled among other Abruzzese *paesani*, near **Assumption Catholic Church**.

### The Elias & Chiarolanzas

**Origin:** The Elia surname traces to southern Italy — most concentrated in **Puglia**, with presence in Calabria, Campania, and Sicily. Yvonne’s mother Mary carried the surname **Chiarolanza** (Americanized to “Chirolanza”) — a rare name meaning “**Bright Lance**” (*chiara* + *lanza*), rooted in **Montecorvino Rovella, Province of Salerno, Campania**.

**The crossing:** The 1940 Census found **Mary Chiarolanza, age 20**, in Bayonne with her father **Alfonso**, mother **Angelina**, and **four sisters**. They had emigrated from Campania and passed through Ellis Island.

**Where they landed:** The same city. Bayonne. The Elia family settled near **Our Lady of Mount Carmel Church** (established 1899) — the heart of the Italian community, just blocks from the Cicconettis. Mary Chiarolanza went to work as a **seamstress at the Maidenform factory** at 154 Avenue E — Bayonne’s largest employer, where Italian-American women sewed garments (and during WWII, parachutes and carrier pigeon vests).

**Frank Elia** — who worked as a poultry processor in Bayonne’s live markets — married Mary Chiarolanza.

#### Check Our Work — The Old Country

| # | We wrote...                                                            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | The Cicconetti name traces to Collepietro, Abruzzo                     |      |       |              |
| 2 | The Chiarolanza family came from Campania, likely Montecorvino Rovella |      |       |              |
| 3 | Mary Chiarolanza worked at the Maidenform factory                      |      |       |              |
| 4 | Frank Elia worked as a poultry processor                               |      |       |              |

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

#### Tell Us a Story

**Dad:** What kind of trouble did you get into growing up in Bayonne? Did you and Dennis ever do something your parents *still* don’t know about?

**Mom:** What’s the dish your mother made that nobody since has gotten right? Close your eyes — what does the old kitchen smell like?

#### Map: Bayonne — Where Two Families Lived

The Cicconettis and the Elias lived within blocks of each other. This map shows Victor’s childhood addresses, both family churches, the Maidenform factory, and Ellis Island — where it all began.

*Interactive map available in the online version.*

## i Bayonne: Why Here?

### The local lens — why two Italian families ended up on this specific peninsula:

Bayonne, New Jersey sits on a narrow spit of land between Newark Bay and New York Harbor — 1.2 square miles, surrounded by water on three sides. In the early 1900s, it was an industrial powerhouse: **Standard Oil** had its largest refinery here (the smell of petroleum was the smell of the city), **Maidenform** sewed bras and girdles (and during WWII, parachutes), and shipyards along the Kill Van Kull built vessels for the Navy.

Industry meant jobs. Jobs meant immigrants. By 1920, Bayonne was over **20% Italian**, with clusters from specific regions: Abruzzesi near Assumption Church, Campanians near Our Lady of Mount Carmel. This wasn't random — it was **chain migration**. One man from Collepietro gets a job at the refinery, writes a letter home, and his cousin follows. Then his cousin's cousin. Within a generation, an entire village has relocated to a ten-block radius in New Jersey.

The Italian neighborhoods had their own economy: bakeries, butchers, live poultry markets (where Frank Elia worked), vegetable gardens in tiny backyards, wine made in basements. The old people spoke Italian; the children spoke English at school and Italian at home. The church was the center of everything — feast days, weddings, funerals, Sunday Mass, the social calendar of a community that had transplanted itself 4,000 miles but kept its roots.

## 1.3 The Unspoken Rule

Nobody sat you down and explained it. There was no speech, no family meeting, no written contract. But every Italian-American kid who grew up in a house like the Cicconettis' or the Elias' understood the deal — it was in the air, in the way your parents looked at you, in the silence after a bad report card, in the pride that radiated off them when you did something right:

**You better be advancing this family.**

That was the immigrant mentality, and it wasn't optional. Your grandparents left everything — their village, their language, their parents' graves — and crossed an ocean in steerage so that *you* could have more than they did. Your parents worked jobs that broke their bodies — refineries, factories, poultry markets, sewing machines — so that *you* wouldn't have to. The debt was enormous, and it was repaid in one currency: **progress**.

Every generation was expected to climb higher than the last:

- The **first generation** (the immigrants) did the crossing. They survived. They got jobs, learned enough English to function, and kept their families fed. That was the mission, and it was enough.
- The **second generation** (Victor Sr., Frank Elia, Eleanor, Mary) was supposed to stabilize. Own a house. Stay out of trouble. Raise children who spoke English without an accent. Send them to school. Get them further from the boat.
- The **third generation** (Vic, Yvonne) was supposed to *arrive*. Get educated. Get a career — not a job, a *career*. Become professionals. Become Americans who nobody could look down on. And then raise children who went even further.

This wasn't pressure in the way modern parenting books describe pressure. It was deeper than that. It was *identity*. You didn't advance just for yourself — you advanced for every person who came before you, for every sacrifice that made your life possible. When Vic got his education degree, that wasn't just Vic

succeeding. That was Collepietro succeeding. That was the steerage crossing paying off. That was the whole project of immigration being *validated*.

And it worked. A poultry processor's daughter married a refinery worker's grandson, and together they produced educators, technologists, and professionals. The immigrant bet — *leave everything, cross the ocean, work until your hands bleed, and trust that the children will rise* — that bet paid off, spectacularly, in the Cicconetti family.

But the mentality never fully left. Even now, even at eighty, Vic's pride in his children's accomplishments — “Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!!” — carries the echo of a grandfather he may never have met, standing on the deck of a steamship, watching the Statue of Liberty appear through the fog, thinking: *this better be worth it*.

It was.

As far back as I can remember, I always wanted to make my family proud. That was the thing. Nobody sat you down and gave you the speech. There was no meeting, no contract, no formal arrangement. But you knew. Every Italian kid in Bayonne knew.

### **You better be advancing this family.**

And it wasn't a suggestion. Your grandparents — these people who left *everything*, I'm talking the village, the language, their own parents' graves in the ground — they crossed an ocean packed like sardines in steerage so that *you* could have it better. Your parents worked jobs that broke them. Refineries. Factories. Poultry markets. Sewing machines. They did that so you wouldn't have to. And the debt? The debt was enormous. And there was only one way to pay it back: **you climb**.

See, in families like ours, there was a system:

- The **first generation** — they did the crossing. That was the whole job. Survive. Get work. Learn enough English to not get cheated. Feed the family. Done.
- The **second generation** — Victor Sr., Frank Elia, Eleanor, Mary — they were supposed to stabilize. Own something. Stay out of trouble. Raise kids who sounded American. Get them further from the boat.
- The **third generation** — that's Vic. That's Yvonne. They were supposed to *arrive*. Education. Career — not a job, a *career*. Professionals. Americans that nobody could look down on. And then? Raise kids who went even further.

This wasn't pressure like some parenting book talks about pressure. This was *identity*. You didn't advance for yourself — you advanced for every person who came before you. Every sacrifice. Every crossing. When Vic got his education degree, that wasn't just Vic. That was Collepietro. That was the whole steerage crossing finally paying off. That was the entire project of immigration being *validated*.

And you know what? It worked. A poultry processor's daughter married a refinery worker's grandson, and together they made educators, technologists, professionals. The immigrant bet — *leave everything, cross the ocean, work until your hands bleed, and trust the kids* — that bet paid off. Spectacularly. In the Cicconetti family.

But the mentality? That never leaves. Even now, at eighty, when Vic writes to his son — “Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!!” — you can hear the echo. Some grandfather he never met, standing on the deck of a steamship, watching Lady Liberty come out of the fog, thinking: *this better be worth it*.

It was worth it.

## i The Italian-American Political Journey

**The wide lens:** The Italian-American political story is one of the great migrations in American electoral history — and it mirrors the family’s journey from survival to arrival.

**The FDR era (1930s–1960s):** The first and second generation were **Democrats**, almost universally. FDR’s New Deal fed them during the Depression. Social Security, labor protections, public works jobs — these programs were lifelines for immigrant families hanging on by their fingernails. The Democratic Party was the party of the working man, and Italian-Americans were working men. In Bayonne, voting Democratic was as natural as going to Mass.

**The JFK moment (1960):** When **John F. Kennedy** won the presidency, Italian-American Catholics wept. A Catholic in the White House. The door was opening. Vic was fourteen. When Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas on **November 22, 1963**, Vic was seventeen — old enough to feel it as a personal loss, not just a news event.

**The Reagan shift (1980s):** By the time Vic was a school administrator, the Italian-American political migration was underway. The children and grandchildren of immigrants had *arrived* — they owned homes, had careers, paid taxes, sent their kids to college. The Democratic Party’s focus was shifting toward constituencies that didn’t look like them. **Ronald Reagan** spoke their language: patriotism, strength, family values, the conviction that America was great because Americans worked hard. The **Reagan Democrat** was born — and in neighborhoods like the ones the Cicconettis came from, the shift was seismic and permanent.

**The close-up:** Vic’s politics are his politics, and they’re consistent with the man: a veteran who loves his country, a law-and-order believer shaped by the neighborhoods he grew up in, a self-made professional who believes in hard work over handouts. He watches **Fox News**. He listens to **Mark Levin**. He forwards articles and commentaries to his sons and his circle. Yvonne is right there with him — same values, same convictions, same channel.

This isn’t a contradiction of the immigrant story. It *is* the immigrant story. The family that crossed the ocean with nothing, worked their way up, and now believes fiercely in the country that made that climb possible — that’s a through line as straight as any in this book.

## 1.4 The American Generation

### i The World in 1946: When Victor Was Born

Victor was born in the spring of 1946 — the first year of the **Baby Boom** — not in Bayonne, but in **New York City**, at the family’s apartment on **10th Street and Avenue C** G in Manhattan’s Lower East Side. His father Victor Sr. was 21, part of the generation that had fought or supported the war effort from the home front. The GI Bill was reshaping America — veterans buying houses, going to college, starting families.

Consider what an Italian-American household looked like the year Victor Cicconetti was born: a walk-up apartment in a tenement neighborhood, shared walls and shared stairwells, the smell of someone else’s dinner coming through the door. The icebox was replacing the iceman, but not everywhere. A radio in the parlor — no television yet. Laundry hung on lines strung between buildings or across fire escapes. The kitchen was the center of the house: where the coffee percolated, the bread was sliced, the arguments were settled. Italian was still spoken at the table — the old country wasn’t old yet. Mass on Sunday was not optional. The men worked with their hands; the women worked with everything else. There was no air conditioning, no dishwasher, no dryer. What there was: family on every floor, neighbors who knew your name, and the unshakeable conviction that the next generation would have it better.

In that same year: the **United Nations** held its first session. Churchill delivered the “Iron Curtain” speech. ENIAC, the first general-purpose computer, was unveiled. The world Vic was born into was inventing itself in real time.

The Cicconettis would stay in that 10th Street apartment until Vic was about ten years old, when the family followed the well-worn path across the Hudson to Bayonne — where Victor Sr.’s people already were, and where an Italian kid from the city could grow up with a little more room to run.

By the time Vic was a teenager in the late 1950s, Bayonne was changing. The children and grandchildren of immigrants were moving to the suburbs. The old neighborhoods were thinning. The refineries were modernizing, needing fewer workers. But the values — family, faith, loyalty, the conviction that America rewards hard work — those stayed.

And Vic was thriving. At **Bayonne High School**, he was a **football star** — the receiver who earned the nickname “**Glue Fingers Cicconetti**” because he didn’t drop the ball. He worked at **Elbaum’s deli**, earning his own money. He had many friends and girlfriends. And when the yearbook came out for the **Class of 1964**, Victor R. Cicconetti was voted **Best Looking**. The kid from the Bayonne row house — the one who walked his future wife to grammar school every morning — was the most popular young man in the building.

## Victor Sr. & Eleanor

**Victor Cicconetti Sr.** was born in Bayonne in **1925** — a son of the immigrant generation. He married **Eleanor Salone**, one of three sisters (Marge, Eleanor, Josie) raised on the **Lower East Side of Manhattan**. Their parents were **Joseph (Giuseppe) Salone** and **Anna (Nunziana Castro) Salone**.

During the Depression, all three Salone sisters spent time in an **orphanage** until their mother Anna found work as a sweatshop seamstress and brought them home. Eleanor eventually followed her sister Marge to Bayonne — the classic pattern of one sibling establishing a foothold and others following.

Victor Sr. and Eleanor started their family in **New York City** — on **10th Street and Avenue C** — before moving to **Bayonne** when young Vic was about ten years old. The family moved several times within Bayonne: 19th St & Broadway, West 21st St, 525 Boulevard, 27th St & Broadway, and finally 700 Boulevard. Before enlisting, Vic lived briefly on his own with friends at **31st St & Avenue E** — his first taste of independence.

They raised **six children**, in order:

- **Victor R.** (~1946, born in NYC)
- **Dennis** (~1947, deceased) — born 18 months after Vic. The two were inseparable through childhood — best friends who did everything together: laundry, cleaning, taking care of the younger siblings still to come. And the late-night baloney sandwiches — always the baloney sandwiches, snuck from the kitchen when the house was dark. That bond was the first brotherhood Vic ever knew.
- **Lee (Leanora)** (~1958) — after Denis, Lee came along and “kinda took over” the older boys’ chores
- **Robert “Bob”** — the handy man
- **Loretta** (d. ~2025)
- **Michael C.** (1961–2009) — the youngest

Victor Sr. struggled with **alcoholism** — a battle that shaped the household and left marks on every child who grew up in it. It was the shadow side of the immigrant story: the pressures of assimilation, of providing, of carrying a family forward in a country that demanded everything and forgave nothing. He died in **1980** at just ~55. Eleanor followed in **1997**.

What Victor Sr. gave his children was complicated — the good and the hard, tangled together. But what his eldest son Vic *did* with that inheritance was unambiguous: he saw what he didn't want to repeat, and he chose differently. That choice would define his life.

## Frank & Mary Elia

**Frank Elia** and **Mary** (nee Chiarolanza) raised their children in Bayonne:

- **Yvonne C. Elia** (~1948)
- **Mary Ann Elia** (later Hurley)
- And others in the extended family circle

But tragedy struck around **1962**: Frank died, leaving Yvonne fatherless at about **fourteen years old**. It was a loss that shaped everything about who Yvonne would become — resilient, caring, fiercely devoted to family.

After Frank's death, Mary married **Anthony Galella** — a man who became a beloved stepfather. His impact was lasting enough that Greg would one day name his own son Anthony in his honor.

Mary Ann married **Michael Hurley Sr.**, who rose to the rank of **Captain** in the Bayonne Police Department. Their daughter Kathy Pacifico has run Forum Fitness Club in Bayonne since 1982. Their son Mike Jr. was honored in 2023 for donating World Trade Center steel for the city's 9/11 memorial.

### Check Our Work — The American Generation

| # | We wrote...                                                           | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 5 | Victor Sr. was born in Bayonne in 1925                                |      |       |              |
| 6 | The six children were: Victor, Dennis, Leanora, Bob, Loretta, Michael |      |       |              |
| 7 | The Salone sisters spent time in an orphanage during the Depression   |      |       |              |
| 8 | Frank died around 1962 when Yvonne was about 14                       |      |       |              |
| 9 | After Frank's death, Mary married Anthony Galella                     |      |       |              |

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

## Tell Us a Story

**Anyone who remembers Victor Sr. and Eleanor:** What were they really like? As parents? As a couple? What's the story the family always tells about them?

**Anyone who remembers Frank Elia or Anthony Galella:** Same question — who were these men beyond what the records can tell us?

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In this same small city — a 1.2-square-mile peninsula where everyone lived within a fifteen-block radius — two Italian-American families were raising the next generation. Their churches were blocks apart. Their neighborhoods overlapped. Their values were the same: hard work, family loyalty, Catholic faith, and the conviction that America offered what the old country never could.

A boy named Victor was growing up on one block. A girl named Yvonne was growing up on another.

Actually — they already knew. Victor, the older kid heading to **Bayonne High School**, would walk young Yvonne to **grammar school** first, then make his way to class. The high schooler and the younger girl, walking the same Bayonne sidewalks every morning. He was already looking out for her before either of them knew what that would become.

So picture this. A city that's one point two square miles. A peninsula. Everybody lives within fifteen blocks of everybody else. Two Italian families, raising kids at the same time. Their churches? Blocks apart. Their neighborhoods? They overlap. Their values? Identical. Work hard. Stay loyal. Go to Mass. Believe in America.

A kid named Victor is growing up on one block. A girl named Yvonne is on another.

And here's the thing — they already knew each other. Vic, the older kid heading to **Bayonne High**, he walks young Yvonne to **grammar school** first, then makes his way to class. Every morning. The high schooler and the younger girl, same Bayonne sidewalks. He's already looking out for her. Neither of them has any idea what that's going to turn into.

But we know. We know exactly where this is going.

## Your Turn

**Dad:** We wrote about Bayonne in the 1940s and 50s — but you *lived* it. What do you actually remember? What was the neighborhood like? Who were the characters? What did you eat? Where did you play? What did your parents' house smell like? What would you want your grandkids to know about growing up Cicconetti in Bayonne?

**Mom:** Same question from the Elia side. What was your Bayonne like? What do you remember about your father Frank? About your mother's sewing at Maidenform? About the neighborhood around Mt. Carmel Church?

**Aunt Leanora:** You've been researching the family tree. What do you know that we got wrong — or missed entirely?



Figure 1.1: Vic at three years old, Fall 1949



Figure 1.2: The Cicconetti family, 1960s



Figure 1.3: School days



Figure 1.4: Family portrait, 1950s

## 2 Two Paths

*One answered the call at nineteen and flew into combat. The other lost her father at fourteen and found her own kind of courage. Both were being forged into the people who would find each other.*

### **i** Soundtrack: Armed Forces Radio (1965–1969)

Vic was 19 when he shipped out. These are the songs that came through Armed Forces Radio and base jukeboxes while he was flying medevac in Southeast Asia:

**The Vietnam Playlist** — *click any song to play*

- [The Animals](#) — “We Gotta Get Out of This Place” (*the unofficial anthem of every soldier in Vietnam*)
- [Creedence Clearwater Revival](#) — “Fortunate Son” / [CCR](#) — “Bad Moon Rising” / [CCR](#) — “Run Through the Jungle”
- [The Doors](#) — “Light My Fire” / [The Doors](#) — “Riders on the Storm”
- [Jimi Hendrix](#) — “All Along the Watchtower” / [Jimi Hendrix](#) — “Purple Haze”
- [Buffalo Springfield](#) — “For What It’s Worth”
- [Rolling Stones](#) — “Paint It Black” / [Rolling Stones](#) — “Gimme Shelter”
- [Steppenwolf](#) — “Born to Be Wild”
- [Otis Redding](#) — “(Sittin’ On) The Dock of the Bay”
- [Sam Cooke](#) — “A Change Is Gonna Come”
- [Smokey Robinson](#) — “The Tracks of My Tears”
- [Marvin Gaye](#) — “I Heard It Through the Grapevine”

*Dad — what do you actually remember hearing over there? Did you have a song that got you through? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (28 photos)

### **i** The World in 1965: Why Young Men from Bayonne Went to War

**The wide lens:** In August 1964, Congress passed the **Gulf of Tonkin Resolution**, giving President Johnson authority to escalate U.S. involvement in Vietnam without a formal declaration of war. By early 1965, the first combat troops landed at Da Nang. The draft was calling 35,000 men per month.

**The local lens:** Working-class cities like Bayonne sent their sons at vastly disproportionate rates. College students got deferments. The sons of lawyers and bankers went to graduate school. The sons of refinery workers and poultry processors went to Southeast Asia. Of the 2.7 million Americans who served in Vietnam, **80% came from working-class or poor families**. Bayonne knew this math intimately.

**The close-up:** Victor was 18. He chose the Air Force — and chose to serve as a medic, not a combat role. It was a decision that said everything about the man he would become: serve, but heal.

## Victor: Answering the Call

Upon graduation from Bayonne High School in **1964** — where he'd been a football star, voted Best Looking, and worked at Elbaum's deli — Victor R. Cicconetti enlisted in the **United States Air Force** as a medic, reporting to **Lackland Air Force Base** in San Antonio, Texas for basic training. He was eighteen years old. It was an era when young men from neighborhoods like Bayonne answered the call without hesitation. Victor's choice to serve as a medic said something about his character from the start: he went to war not to fight, but to heal. G

He's eighteen years old. Best Looking in the senior class, football star, the kid slicing prosciutto at Elbaum's deli after school. And in **1964**, Vic Cicconetti walks out of Bayonne High and into a recruiter's office. Just like that. No hand-wringing, no running off to college to dodge it. That wasn't how it worked in Bayonne. You got called, you went. But here's the thing about Vic — he didn't sign up to carry a rifle. He signed up as a **medic**. Tells you everything you need to know about the guy. He's going to war, but he's going to war to put people back together. Reports to **Lackland Air Force Base** in San Antonio, Texas. Kid from a peninsula in Jersey who'd never been farther than the Shore, and now he's in Texas. G

## Medical Air Evacuations

Victor's service took him into the skies over Southeast Asia, where he participated in **medical air evacuations** — the critical missions that transported wounded servicemembers from combat zones to medical facilities.

After training, Victor was stationed at **Barksdale Air Force Base in Shreveport, Louisiana** from **1966 to 1967** — the same period he married Yvonne back in Bayonne. In **1968**, he deployed to **U-Tapao Royal Thai Air Force Base in Thailand**, the hub for U.S. air operations over Southeast Asia — arriving during the **Tet Offensive**, the massive coordinated attack by North Vietnamese forces that turned the war and turned American public opinion with it. As a medic on evacuation flights, Victor was responsible for keeping patients alive during transport, often under dangerous and chaotic conditions. Medical skill under extreme pressure. Courage in combat zones. Compassion for fellow servicemembers at their most vulnerable.

The nickname "**MedFlyBoy**" — which Vic later used as his Gmail handle — captures both halves of his identity: the **medic** who healed and the **flyboy** who took to the skies. A name born in the Air Force, carried for life.

Now here's where it gets real. They didn't put Vic behind a desk. They put him in the sky. **Medical air evacuations** — you fly into a combat zone, you load up wounded guys, and you keep them alive while the plane gets the hell out. That's the job.

After training, they station him at **Barksdale Air Force Base in Shreveport, Louisiana, 1966 to 1967**. Same period he marries Yvonne back in Bayonne — but we'll get to that. Then in **1968**, they send him to **U-Tapao Royal Thai Air Force Base in Thailand**. The hub. The center of everything. And he arrives right in the middle of the **Tet Offensive** — the whole war turning upside down, the enemy hitting everywhere at once, and suddenly everybody back home watching it on TV realizes this thing is not going the way they were told. And Vic? Vic's on the plane. He's the guy keeping some kid from Ohio alive at thirty thousand feet with blood on his hands and the airframe shaking. You don't talk about it later. You just don't. But you carry it.

"**MedFlyBoy**" — that's what they called him. The medic who flew. He liked it enough to make it his Gmail handle decades later. Half healer, half flyboy. A name born in the Air Force, carried for life.

## **i** Map: The Air Force Journey — Bayonne to Thailand

From a Bayonne neighborhood to basic training in San Antonio, then Shreveport, then halfway around the world to Thailand — and back.

*Interactive map available in the online version.*

### **Four Years**

From 1964 to 1969, Victor served — Lackland, Shreveport, Thailand, and back. He was twenty-three when he came home — no longer the teenager who had left Bayonne, but a man shaped by what he had seen, what he had done, and who he had saved.

Coming home from Vietnam in the late 1960s was its own challenge. The welcome was famously inadequate. But what distinguished Victor was what he did next: he didn't retreat, and he didn't forget.

Four years. 1964 to 1969. Lackland, Shreveport, Thailand, and back. He walks out of Bayonne a teenager. He comes home at twenty-three, and he's not that kid anymore. You can't be. Not after what he saw, what he did, who he kept alive — and who he didn't.

And here's the thing nobody tells you about coming home from Vietnam in the late sixties. There's no parade. There's no thank you. Some guys, people spit on them at the airport. That actually happened. The whole country decided it didn't like the war, and it took it out on the guys who went. But Vic? He didn't crawl into a hole. He didn't get bitter. He came home and he got to work. That's the Bayonne in him. That's the Cicconetti in him.

### **Yvonne: Finding Her Strength**

While Victor was in Southeast Asia, Yvonne C. Elia was growing up fast in Bayonne.

Now while Vic's halfway around the world dodging who-knows-what, back in Bayonne, Yvonne Elia is dealing with her own thing. And it ain't easy.

### **A Father Lost**

Around **1962**, when Yvonne was about fourteen, her father **Frank Elia** died. In an instant, the world shifted. The girl who had grown up in the warmth of an Italian-American household — the church, the neighborhood, the family table — now had to find a different kind of strength.

Her mother Mary, the seamstress from Maidenform, held the family together. And when Mary later married **Anthony Galella**, Yvonne gained a stepfather who would earn the family's love so deeply that a grandson would carry his name.

Around **1962**, she's fourteen years old and her father **Frank Elia** drops dead. Just like that. One day you got a father, the next day you don't. And in an Italian family, that's — I mean, that's everything. The whole world tilts. The church, the neighborhood, the Sunday table — all of it changes when the old man's chair is empty.

But the mother, Mary — the seamstress from Maidenform — she holds it together. She does what Italian women do. She keeps the house running, keeps the kids fed, keeps going. And later, when she marries **Anthony Galella**, the family gets a stepfather so good that years down the road, a grandson's gonna carry his name. That tells you something.

## Her Own Ambitions

Yvonne channeled her resilience into education. She would go on to build a distinguished career as a **health teacher and coordinator in the Jersey City public school system** — decades of dedicated service to students’ wellbeing. After retiring in 2005, she served as an **Allied Health Vocational advisor** for the Hudson County Vocational School District, earning **multiple awards** for connecting young people with healthcare careers.

But that career was still ahead of her. In the mid-1960s, Yvonne was a young woman in Bayonne, shaped by loss but driven by strength, building the foundation of who she would become.

So what does Yvonne do with all that? She doesn’t feel sorry for herself. She goes into education. Becomes a **health teacher and coordinator in the Jersey City public school system** — decades of it. Decades. Then she retires in 2005 and she’s not done — she becomes an **Allied Health Vocational advisor** for the Hudson County Vocational School District, picking up **multiple awards** for getting young people into healthcare careers. The woman doesn’t stop.

But that’s all later. In the mid-1960s, she’s just a young woman in Bayonne figuring it out. Loss behind her. Strength in front of her. Building herself into someone.

## Her Sister Mary Ann

Through it all, Yvonne’s sister **Mary Ann** was at her side. The bond between the Elia sisters — forged in the shared loss of their father and the strength of their mother — would remain one of the great constants of the extended family. Mary Ann would later marry Michael Hurley, run a pizza bistro in Bayonne, and raise children who would become community pillars in their own right.

And through all of it — every bit of it — her sister **Mary Ann** is right there. That’s how it works with sisters in these families. You lose your father together, you grow up together, you don’t let go. Mary Ann marries Michael Hurley, they run a pizza bistro in Bayonne, they raise kids who turn into pillars of the community. The Elia sisters. You don’t bet against them.

### Check Our Work — Two Paths

| # | We wrote...                                                          | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Victor joined the Air Force in 1964 at age 18; basic at Lackland AFB |      |       |              |
| 2 | He served as a medic and flew medical air evacuations                |      |       |              |
| 3 | “MedFlyBoy” was his nickname from service                            |      |       |              |
| 4 | Yvonne was born approximately April 1948                             |      |       |              |

5 Yvonne lost her father  
at about age 14

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

### Tell Us a Story

**Dad:** Was there one specific moment in Vietnam that changed who you were? And when you landed back in the States — who was the first person you wanted to see?

**Mom:** What did you think when this young man showed up in uniform? Be honest — was it love at first sight, or did he have to work for it?

## 2.1 Two Paths Converge

By the late 1960s, Victor had returned from Vietnam. Yvonne was finding her way in Bayonne.

Both had been tested. Both had been forged by experience — his by war, hers by loss. Both carried the values of their Italian-American upbringing: faith, family, resilience, and the belief that you show up for the people who need you.

In Bayonne, New Jersey — a city small enough that everyone knew everyone — Victor Cicconetti and Yvonne Elia found each other.

So now it's the late sixties. Vic's back from Vietnam. Yvonne's finding her footing in Bayonne. And here's the beautiful part of the story.

Both of them got tested. Him by war. Her by loss. Both of them came through it. And both of them grew up with the same playbook — the Italian-American playbook. Faith. Family. You work hard. You don't quit. And when somebody needs you, you show up. Period.

Bayonne, New Jersey. One point two square miles. Everybody knows everybody. In a city that small, Victor Cicconetti and Yvonne Elia were always going to find each other. It was just a matter of when.

### Your Turn — Dad

We wrote that you flew medevac missions in Southeast Asia. But we don't know the details — and we'd love to hear whatever you're willing to share.

- Where were you stationed? Which bases?
- What was a typical mission like?
- Do you remember specific flights or patients?
- What was it like coming home in 1969?
- Is “MedFlyBoy” really from the service, or did that come later?

*You don't have to answer all of these. Even one story would make this chapter come alive.*

## **i** Your Turn — Mom

We wrote about losing your father at fourteen. We know that shaped you — but only you know how.

- What do you remember about your dad Frank?
- What was it like after he died? How did your mother hold things together?
- When did you know you wanted to go into education?
- What was it like watching Victor leave for Vietnam?



Figure 2.1: In uniform, summer 1965



Figure 2.2: Air Force, April 1966



Figure 2.3: “For My Honey — Forever I’ll Love You,” March 1967



Figure 2.4: Bangkok, King's Palace, June 1968



Figure 2.5: Unit photo, January 1968



Figure 2.6: Summer 1968

## 3 August 20, 1967

*“Mommy feels the same way and I am sure she will speak to you.”* — Vic, in an email to Greg, 2015. Even fifty years later, they speak as one.

### **i** Soundtrack: August 20, 1967

Vic and Yvonne married during the Summer of Love. These songs were on the radio the week they said “I do” at Assumption Church:

**The Wedding Year** — *click any song to play*

- [Aretha Franklin](#) — “Respect” (*#1 that summer*)
- [The Beatles](#) — “All You Need Is Love” (*released July ’67*)
- [The Righteous Brothers](#) — “Unchained Melody”
- [Percy Sledge](#) — “When a Man Loves a Woman”
- [Ben E. King](#) — “Stand By Me”
- [Etta James](#) — “At Last”
- [The Temptations](#) — “My Girl”
- [Sam Cooke](#) — “You Send Me”
- [Elvis Presley](#) — “Can’t Help Falling in Love”

*Mom & Dad — what was your first dance? What song was “yours”? Do you remember the music at the reception? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (7 photos)

### 3.1 The Columns Merge

On **August 20, 1967**, Victor R. Cicconetti married **Yvonne C. Elia** at **Assumption Catholic Church in Bayonne, New Jersey**.

He was twenty-one. She was nineteen. In Yvonne’s words: Victor married **“his childhood sweetheart.”** The boy who had walked her to grammar school before heading to Bayonne High — the football star, the Best Looking in his class — had never really left her orbit. The Vietnam War was raging — Victor was in the middle of his Air Force service. But they chose each other, and from this day forward, the two family lines that had traveled separately from Italy to Bayonne became one story.

She was nineteen. He was twenty-one. In August 1967 — the summer the whole country was on fire — these two kids from Bayonne walk into Assumption Catholic Church and they get married.

Now you gotta understand something. Vic Cicconetti and Yvonne Elia? This wasn’t some arranged thing, some setup at a cousin’s communion. This was the real deal. He’d been walking her to grammar school since they were kids. The football star, the Best Looking in his class — and he never once took his eyes off

this girl. She called him her “childhood sweetheart,” and she meant it. The guy was in the middle of his Air Force service, Vietnam’s raging, the whole world’s coming apart — and what does he do? He marries the girl from the neighborhood. Because that’s what you do when you know. And Vic knew.

From this day forward, two family lines that traveled separately all the way from Italy to Bayonne? One story.

### **i** August 1967: The Summer the World Was on Fire

**The wide lens:** The summer Vic and Yvonne married was one of the most turbulent in American history. It would later be called the “**Long Hot Summer**” — over 150 race riots erupted across U.S. cities.

**The local lens:** Five weeks before the wedding — **July 12–17, 1967** — the **Newark riots** tore through a city less than 20 miles from Assumption Church. Twenty-six people died. Over 700 were injured. The National Guard rolled armored vehicles through streets that Bayonne families drove through every day. The smoke was visible from the waterfront.

Bayonne itself was tense. The city’s Italian-American neighborhoods bordered Black neighborhoods. The police force — where Yvonne’s brother-in-law Michael Hurley would later serve — was on high alert. This was the America that Vic and Yvonne were building their life inside.

**The wide lens:** That same summer — **100,000 American troops** were in Vietnam. The Six-Day War had just reshaped the Middle East in June. Muhammad Ali had been stripped of his title for refusing the draft. The Beatles released *Sgt. Pepper’s*. Thurgood Marshall was confirmed as the first Black Supreme Court Justice.

And on August 20, in the middle of all of it, a young airman on active duty and a girl from the neighborhood walked into Assumption Church and said yes.

It would prove to be the great constant of both their lives.

## **The Early Marriage Odyssey**

Before the partnership settled into its rhythm, it moved — a lot. The first decade of the Cicconetti marriage was an odyssey of addresses, seven homes in eleven years, the kind of restless motion that young families with limited means and big ambitions know intimately:

1. **84 Humphrey’s Ave, Bayonne** (1969–1971) — Their first home together after Victor’s discharge. Back in Bayonne, starting from scratch.
2. **Washington Parkway, Bayonne** (1971) — A brief stay.
3. **493 Avenue A, Bayonne** (1971) — Another brief stop.
4. **San Diego, California** (1971) — In Yvonne’s words: “we fled to San Diego for a few months.” Not military — just young and restless, two newlyweds chasing an adventure. The only time Vic and Yvonne lived outside the New York–New Jersey orbit.
5. **31st Street, Bayonne** (1972–1974) — Back to Bayonne. Greg was born during this stretch.
6. **158 West 21st Street, Bayonne** (1974–1977) — The family growing, the apartments getting a little bigger.
7. **Avenue E, Bayonne** (1977–1980) — The **first home they owned**. Rich was born. After years of renting, moving, and making do, they finally had something that was theirs.

But it wasn’t all addresses and logistics. Yvonne remembers the early years with joy: “It was fun times with friends, rock concerts, Jersey Shore, vacations.” Two kids from Bayonne, out in the world, figuring it out together.

Seven addresses in eleven years. That's not instability — that's a young couple climbing. Every move was a step: from a discharge apartment to a family home, from renting to owning, from Bayonne to (briefly) California and back. By 1980, when they left Bayonne for good and headed to the Jersey Shore, they had earned every square foot of the life ahead of them.

It would prove to be the great constant of both their lives.

## The Early Marriage Odyssey

Now here's the thing about the Cicconettis in those early years — they couldn't sit still. Seven addresses in eleven years. You hear that and you think, what, they got problems? No. They were climbing. That's what young couples with no money and big plans do. They move. They hustle. They figure it out.

1. **84 Humphrey's Ave, Bayonne** (1969–1971) — First place after Vic gets discharged. Back in Bayonne, starting from zero.
2. **Washington Parkway, Bayonne** (1971) — Brief stay. In and out.
3. **493 Avenue A, Bayonne** (1971) — Another quick stop. You're getting the picture.
4. **San Diego, California** (1971) — And then — get this — they flee to San Diego. Yvonne's word, not mine: "*we fled.*" Not military, not a transfer. Just two newlyweds who said, you know what, let's get outta here for a while. The only time Vic and Yvonne ever lived outside the Jersey–New York orbit. A few months, and then they came back. Because of course they came back. You always come back.
5. **31st Street, Bayonne** (1972–1974) — Back in Bayonne. Greg shows up during this stretch.
6. **158 West 21st Street, Bayonne** (1974–1977) — Family's growing. Apartments getting a little bigger each time.
7. **Avenue E, Bayonne** (1977–1980) — And here it is. The **first home they owned**. Rich is born. After years of renting, moving, making do with what they had — they finally got something that was theirs.

And look, it wasn't all U-Hauls and lease agreements. Yvonne remembers it with a smile: "*Fun times with friends, rock concerts, Jersey Shore, vacations.*" Two kids from Bayonne, out in the world, having a blast while they figured the whole thing out.

Seven addresses. Eleven years. That's not instability — that's ambition with a moving truck. Every stop was a step up. Renting to owning. Bayonne to California and back. And by 1980, when they left Bayonne for good and headed down the Shore, they'd earned every square foot of what came next.

## 3.2 A Partnership Built to Last

What makes a marriage last nearly sixty years? The Cicconetti answer, visible in every email Vic sends and every milestone the family celebrates, is this: **two people who show up for each other, every single day, without exception.**

The partnership has weathered:

- **Vietnam-era separation** — newly married, with Victor deployed overseas as a medic
- **Career building** — Victor in school administration (Long Branch, Asbury Park), Yvonne in health education (Jersey City) — two educators under one roof
- **Entrepreneurial risk** — co-owning an Italian restaurant as a family venture
- **Raising two sons** — Greg and Rich
- **Four grandchildren** — Ellie, Anthony, Richie, and Jessie
- **Loss** — Victor's parents, his brothers Dennis and Michael, his sister Loretta, Yvonne's father Frank

Through all of it, the partnership held. More than held — it flourished.

You wanna know what makes a marriage last sixty years? I'll tell you. You show up. Every day. No exceptions. That's it. That's the whole secret. And these two? They showed up.

Look at what they went through:

- **Vietnam** — they just got married and he's overseas as a medic. She's home, waiting. You think that's easy?
- **Two careers** — Vic in school administration, Long Branch, Asbury Park. Yvonne in health education over in Jersey City. Two educators under one roof. You know how many opinions that is?
- **The restaurant** — they opened an Italian restaurant. As a family. If you've ever worked with your spouse in a kitchen during a Friday night rush, you know that's either gonna make you or break you.
- **Two sons** — Greg and Rich.
- **Four grandkids** — Ellie, Anthony, Richie, and Jessie.
- **Loss** — and this is the part nobody talks about. Vic lost his parents. He lost his brothers Dennis and Michael. His sister Loretta. Yvonne lost her father Frank. That's a lot of funerals. That's a lot of holding each other up.

Through all of it — every bit of it — the partnership held. It more than held. It flourished.

 Check Our Work — The Wedding

| # | We wrote...                                            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | You married on August 20, 1967                         |      |       |              |
| 2 | The wedding was at Assumption Catholic Church, Bayonne |      |       |              |
| 3 | Victor was 21, Yvonne was 19                           |      |       |              |
| 4 | Victor was still in the Air Force when you married     |      |       |              |

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

 Tell Us a Story

**Dad & Mom:** Who made the first move? Who chased who? What did you *really* think of each other on the first date? Come on — you've been married almost sixty years. You can finally tell us.

### 3.3 How They Operate

Vic's emails reveal a partnership where both voices matter but the rhythm is distinctly theirs. When Greg shared career milestones, Vic responded first — immediate, warm, emotional:

“Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!! Congratulations for a job well done.”

And then the tell:

“Mommy feels the same way and I am sure she will speak to you.”

That's Victor: he speaks with his whole heart, then defers to Yvonne for her own word. He doesn't presume to speak for her. He announces her. Two voices, one team.

Now here's where you really see how they work. You read Vic's emails — and I've read a lot of them — and there's this pattern. It's beautiful. Greg tells his dad some big career news and Vic fires back immediately. No delay. Pure emotion:

“Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!! Congratulations for a job well done.”

And then — and this is the part that gets me — he drops this line:

“Mommy feels the same way and I am sure she will speak to you.”

You catch that? He doesn't speak for her. He *announces* her. He's saying: I'm telling you how I feel, and she's gonna tell you how she feels, because we're two separate people who happen to be one team. That's not something you learn. That's something you are.

### 3.4 The 40th Anniversary

In **2007**, the family gathered at the home of **Mary Ann and Michael Hurley** in Stafford, NJ, to celebrate Victor and Yvonne's **40th wedding anniversary**. The milestone was marked with a family party and a feature in the *Asbury Park Press* anniversaries section.

Now, nearly twenty years later, three grandchildren — Ellie, Anthony, and Richie — have grown up, the careers have given way to retirement, and the wedding that began at Assumption Church has become one of the longest-running love stories in the family.

Forty years. **2007**. The whole family comes together at Mary Ann and Michael Hurley's place in Stafford. A party. The *Asbury Park Press* runs it in the anniversaries section. Forty years married, and they made the paper.

And now? Nearly twenty years after that party. The grandkids — Ellie, Anthony, Richie — they grew up. The careers wound down. Retirement kicked in. And that wedding at Assumption Church? It turned into one of the longest-running love stories this family's ever seen. And it's still going.

### 3.5 This Book Is Their Story

From this chapter forward, this book tells the joint story of Victor and Yvonne — with Vic as the lead, because it's his 80th birthday. But make no mistake: every chapter that follows is also Yvonne's story. Every achievement of Vic's was built on the foundation she provided. Every family milestone was celebrated together.

When Yvonne's birthday comes, we'll tell this story again — with her in the spotlight, her career foregrounded, her voice leading. The same partnership, seen from the other side.

For now: this is Vic's turn. And it starts here, at the altar, on August 20, 1967.

So from here on out, this book? It's both of them. Vic gets top billing because it's his 80th, that's how it works. But don't kid yourself — every chapter that follows is Yvonne's story too. Every single thing Vic accomplished? She was the foundation. Every milestone? Celebrated together. That's how they do it.

When Yvonne's birthday rolls around, we're gonna tell the whole thing again. Her spotlight. Her career up front. Her voice leading. Same partnership, other side of the lens.

But right now? This is Vic's turn. And it starts right here, at the altar, August 20, 1967.

### **i** Your Turn — Dad & Mom

This is the chapter we can't write without you. We know the date (August 20, 1967) and the place (Assumption Church). But the *story*?

- **How did you two meet?** Was it a setup? A chance encounter? Did you know right away?
- **What was the wedding like?** Big or small? Who was there? What do you remember most?
- **What was it like being newlyweds with a war on?** Mom, what was it like when Dad was overseas?
- **What's the secret?** Nearly sixty years. What makes it work?
- **Dad:** What would you want to say about Mom in this book?
- **Mom:** What would you want to say about Dad?

*This chapter will only be as good as what you give us. And we want it to be the best chapter in the book.*



Figure 3.1: Mom & Dad's wedding day, August 20, 1967



Figure 3.2: The happy couple



Figure 3.3: Wedding party



Figure 3.4: At the reception

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*From this day forward, the two columns become one. The Cicconetti-Elia story is a partnership — and it has lasted nearly sixty years and counting.*

*Two columns. One story. Nearly sixty years and still going. That's not a marriage — that's a dynasty.*

## **Part II**

# **Part II: The Life They Built**

## 4 Man with Many Missions

*“Man with Many Missions” — headline from the Red Bank Register, 1987, profiling Victor at Long Branch High School*

### **i** Soundtrack: The Jersey Years (1970s–1990s)

Vic was a school administrator in Monmouth County during the golden age of Jersey rock. These artists weren’t just on the radio — they were playing down the road at the Stone Pony in Asbury Park, Vic’s own school district:

**Bruce, Billy, and the Boys** — *click any song to play*

- Bruce Springsteen — “Born to Run” / Bruce Springsteen — “Thunder Road” / Bruce Springsteen — “Glory Days” / Bruce Springsteen — “My Hometown”
- Tom Petty — “American Girl” / Tom Petty — “Free Fallin’” / Tom Petty — “Running Down a Dream” / Tom Petty — “I Won’t Back Down”
- Billy Joel — “Piano Man” / Billy Joel — “Scenes from an Italian Restaurant” (*come on, it’s perfect*) / Billy Joel — “My Life”
- Bon Jovi — “Livin’ on a Prayer” / Bon Jovi — “Wanted Dead or Alive” (*Jersey boys*)
- Bob Seger — “Old Time Rock and Roll” / Bob Seger — “Night Moves”
- Eagles — “Hotel California” / Eagles — “Take It Easy”
- Fleetwood Mac — “Dreams” / Fleetwood Mac — “Go Your Own Way”
- Steely Dan — “Reelin’ in the Years” / Steely Dan — “Do It Again”

*What blasted out of the family station wagon? What song did Dad crank up when he thought nobody was listening? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (24 photos)

## 4.1 From Battlefield to Classroom

### **i** America Through Vic’s Education Career (1970–2000)

**The wide lens:** Vic entered education during a period of extraordinary upheaval in American schools and society. The thirty years he spent as an administrator spanned:

- **1970s:** Post-Vietnam malaise, Watergate, oil crisis, stagflation. Schools navigated desegregation, busing conflicts, and the first wave of federal education mandates. New Jersey’s **Robinson v. Cahill** ruling (1973) established that the state must equalize school funding — a battle that would define NJ education for decades.
- **1980s:** The Reagan revolution. In **1983**, the federal report ***A Nation at Risk*** declared that “the educational foundations of our society are presently being eroded by a rising tide of

mediocrity.” The Challenger explosion (**January 28, 1986**) — with teacher Christa McAuliffe aboard — was watched live in classrooms across America. Black Monday (**October 19, 1987**) crashed stock markets. That same year, the *Red Bank Register* was profiling Vic as “Man with Many Missions.”

- **1990s:** The **LA riots** erupted in **April 1992** after the Rodney King verdict — six days of fires, 63 dead, \$1 billion in damage. Schools across America grappled with race, justice, and how to talk to students about a world that seemed to be unraveling on live television. Then **Columbine** in **April 1999** — 13 dead in a suburban high school — changed school security forever.

**The New Jersey lens:** In 1990, the NJ Supreme Court’s **Abbott v. Burke** decision identified **31 “Abbott districts”** — the state’s poorest urban school systems — and mandated that the state fund them at the same level as the wealthiest suburbs. Both **Asbury Park** and **Long Branch** were Abbott districts. Vic wasn’t administering schools in quiet suburbs — he was in the districts where the fight over equity, funding, and opportunity was most intense.

**The close-up:** Through all of this, Vic showed up. Every day, every year, for three decades. A Vietnam veteran running schools in communities that needed steady leadership. A man who had seen combat choosing to spend his career in service to young people — many of them from the same working-class backgrounds he came from.

After his military service ended in 1969, Victor built a second career dedicated to a different kind of service: **the education of New Jersey’s young people**. He would spend decades as a public school administrator — a career that touched the lives of countless students across some of the state’s most dynamic communities.

The transition from Air Force medic to educator was not as unlikely as it might seem. Both roles demanded the same core qualities: patience, discipline, compassion, and the ability to lead under pressure. The young man who had kept wounded soldiers alive during medical evacuations now channeled that same dedication into building futures for students.

But first, he had to earn it. While attending **St. Peter’s College**, Vic worked every job he could find — **roofer, plumber, tutor** — whatever he could do to make money and keep the family afloat while he got his degree. A young veteran with a wife and a growing family, scrambling between construction sites and classrooms. That hustle was the bridge between the Air Force and the career ahead.

And underneath it, the unspoken rule was still operating. Vic’s parents had stabilized the family in America. Now it was Vic’s turn to *arrive* — to become a professional, to earn a career with a title and a desk and a pension. Not a job at the refinery. Not a trade. A *career*. The immigrant project demanded it, and Vic delivered.

So the war ends. Vic comes home. And what does he do? He does the thing nobody expects a twenty-three-year-old combat medic to do. He goes into education. The education of New Jersey’s young people — and he’s going to spend thirty years doing it.

Now, you’d think — medic to teacher, that’s a big jump. It’s not. Think about it. Patience. Discipline. Compassion. The ability to stay calm when everything around you is going sideways. He was already trained for this. The guy who kept wounded soldiers alive on medevac flights? He’s going to keep teenagers alive in a different way.

But first — first he had to earn it. He’s going to **St. Peter’s College**, and he’s working every job he can find. **Roofer. Plumber. Tutor.** Whatever pays. He’s got a wife and a growing family, and he’s scrambling between construction sites and classrooms. Up on somebody’s roof at six AM, in a lecture hall by noon, home by dinner to a family that needs him. That hustle? That was the bridge.

And the unspoken rule is still running in the background. His parents stabilized the family in America. Now it's Vic's turn to *arrive*. Not a job at the refinery. Not a trade. A *career*. Title on the door. Desk in the office. Pension at the end. The immigrant project demanded it. And Vic delivered.

## October 1, 1974

Some dates carry double weight. On **October 1, 1974**, two things happened simultaneously: Victor and Yvonne's first son **Gregory** was born — and Victor signed his **first teaching contract at Bayonne High School**. The same day. A son and a career, arriving together. The man who'd been roofing houses and fixing pipes to pay for college was now officially a teacher, and a father, in the same twenty-four hours.

## 4.2 Long Branch High School

Victor's career at **Long Branch High School** wasn't a single role — it was a climb. In **1989**, he was offered the position of **department head of Business Education** — and he used it to **develop the first technology program for the entire district**. He eventually rose to **assistant principal**. Each step reflected the same pattern: Vic didn't just show up and do the job — he built, he led, he pushed for more.

### The Computer Pioneer

#### **i** 1982: When Computers Were Still Science Fiction

**The wide lens:** In 1982, the personal computer was barely a consumer product. IBM had released the PC in August 1981. Apple's Lisa was still a year away. The Macintosh wouldn't arrive until 1984. Most American schools had *zero* computers. The ones that did had a single machine in a closet somewhere, gathering dust.

**The school lens:** Getting computers into a New Jersey public high school in the early 1980s required more than a purchase order. It required **grant money** — and the hustle to find it, write the proposals, and convince administrators and school boards that these strange beige boxes were the future.

**The close-up:** Vic became famous at Long Branch for exactly this: **bringing in grant money to put computers in classrooms**. While other schools were debating whether to invest, Vic was already writing grants, acquiring machines, and getting students' hands on keyboards.

Victor was ahead of his time on technology. He became known at Long Branch for his ability to **bring in grant funding** to get computers into the school — at a time when most educators were still skeptical. He founded the school's **Stock Market Club**, teaching students about investing, finance, and the real-world applications of the business curriculum he'd built.

The Cicconetti home was a reflection of his conviction. From **around 1982 onward**, there was always a computer of some kind in the house:

- **Commodore 64** and **VIC-20** — the machines that brought computing to middle-class American homes
- The full parade of **floppy disk formats** — from the massive 8-inch floppies to the 5¼-inch disks to the 3½-inch “hard” floppies
- Each generation replaced by the next, because Vic stayed current

The kids grew up with computers not because they were wealthy, but because their father was a public school teacher who understood where the world was going — and made sure his students AND his children were ready for it.

It paid off. Vic's desire to stay on the cutting edge of computing planted a seed — and the unspoken rule did the rest. His son Greg would take that inheritance to the next level, building a career in biostatistics, computational drug development, and data science. A Ph.D. from UConn. A faculty appointment. Research Fellow at AbbVie. The through line from a business teacher writing grants for Commodore 64s to a son building statistical models for drug development is straighter than it looks.

Four generations: a stone village in the Apennines → steerage class → a refinery town → a public school teacher hustling for computer grants → a Research Fellow. The immigrant bet, compounding.

## **“Man with Many Missions”**

In **1987**, the *Red Bank Register* published a profile of Victor titled **“Man with Many Missions”** — a piece that captured the remarkable breadth of his life experience. The article included a photograph of Victor working at a computer at the school and described him as embodying “an American story,” noting his journey from military service through education.

That headline — “Man with Many Missions” — became something of an unofficial motto. It captured Victor's essential nature: a man who never limited himself to a single role, a single community, or a single way of serving.

## **April 1992: The Walkout**

Then came the moment that tested everything.

On **April 29, 1992**, a jury in Simi Valley, California acquitted four LAPD officers of beating **Rodney King** — despite the entire country having watched the videotape. Los Angeles erupted. Six days of fires, 63 dead, over \$1 billion in damage. The images — buildings burning, the National Guard on American streets, Rodney King asking “Can we all get along?” — were broadcast into every living room and every school in America.

The shock wave reached Long Branch.

**The students of Long Branch High School walked out of class.**

Imagine the scene. A diverse student body in a working-class Shore city, watching their country tear itself apart on television, feeling the injustice in their bones — and deciding they couldn't sit in a classroom and pretend it wasn't happening. They walked out. Hundreds of students, out the doors, into the open.

Now imagine being the administration. The faculty. The people responsible for the safety of every one of those kids. What do you do? Call the police? Lock the doors? Stand in their way? Let them go and hope for the best?

Victor Cicconetti did none of those things. **He walked out with them.**

And then he did something that no handbook prescribed, no training manual suggested, and no other administrator in the public school system of Long Branch, New Jersey was likely to attempt: **he led the students in prayer.**

Right there. Outside the school. A Vietnam veteran, a public school assistant principal, standing in front of a crowd of angry, scared, heartbroken teenagers — and bringing them together in the only way he knew how. Not with a megaphone. Not with threats. Not with rules. With *prayer*.

A photographer from the *Asbury Park Press* was there. The photo made the paper: **Vic, leading students in prayer during the Long Branch High School walkout after the Rodney King verdict.**

That photograph has been **blown up, framed, and hung on the wall of the Cicconetti garage G** — the garage that became the family’s gathering spot, where Dad and the kids hung out, where the walls told the story of a life. And on that wall, among everything else, is the moment that captured who Victor Cicconetti really was when it mattered most.

**What’s the message?** Greg puts it simply: *He stood up. He took action to modulate that crowd. And he calmed them. That’s what leaders do.* And he used the tactic of prayer — in a public school, where others wouldn’t have dared — because in that moment, the right thing to do and the safe thing to do were not the same thing. Vic chose the right thing.

The medic who healed in Vietnam. The teacher who brought computers to classrooms. The father who bumped a rifle score by a point. The assistant principal who walked into a student walkout and turned a potential riot into a prayer circle.

Man with Many Missions. The *Red Bank Register* had no idea how right they were.

And then came the moment. The moment that proved everything.

April 29, 1992. A jury in Simi Valley acquits four cops for beating **Rodney King**. The whole country watched the tape. Everybody saw it. And these twelve people said “not guilty.” LA went up in flames. Six days. Sixty-three dead. A billion dollars in damage. National Guard rolling down American streets. Rodney King on television asking “Can we all get along?”

The shock wave hits Long Branch.

**The kids walk out.**

Now picture this. Hundreds of students — diverse, working-class Shore kids — they’ve been watching their country rip itself apart on the classroom TVs. And they decide they’re done. They can’t sit there and pretend this isn’t happening. They walk out the doors. Into the open.

You’re an administrator. You’re responsible for every single one of these kids. What do you do? Call the cops? Lock the building? Stand in the doorway and say “get back inside”?

Vic Cicconetti did none of that. **He walked out with them.**

And then — and this is the part that still gives me chills — he did something no handbook prescribed, no training manual suggested, and no other administrator in the public school system of Long Branch, New Jersey would have *dreamed* of attempting: **he led them in prayer.**

Right there. Outside. A Vietnam veteran. A public school assistant principal. Standing in front of a crowd of angry, scared, heartbroken teenagers. And he brings them together the only way he knows how. Not with a megaphone. Not with threats. With *prayer*.

A photographer from the *Asbury Park Press* was there. The photo made the paper. And that photo? It’s been **blown up, framed, and hung on the wall of the Cicconetti garage G** — the garage where Dad and the kids hung out, where the walls tell the whole story. And on that wall, right there with everything else, is the moment that shows you exactly who this man is when it matters.

He stood up. He took action. He calmed them. That’s what leaders do. And he used prayer — in a public school, where everybody else would’ve been too scared — because the right thing to do and the safe thing to do were not the same thing. Vic chose the right thing.

The medic who healed in Vietnam. The teacher who brought in computers. The father who bumped a rifle score. The assistant principal who walked into a walkout and turned it into a prayer circle.

Man with Many Missions. The *Red Bank Register* had no idea how right they were.

 The Doppelgänger

The family has long joked that Vic’s **black doppelgänger is Jesse Jackson**. The resemblance is uncanny — the bearing, the build, the look. So when you picture Vic leading a diverse group of students in prayer outside a New Jersey high school in April 1992... you’re not far off from a scene that Jesse Jackson himself might have led. Sometimes life casts you perfectly.

 Check Our Work — Education Career

| #  | We wrote...                                                          | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1  | Vic started as a teacher in the business department at Long Branch   |      |       |              |
| 2  | He rose to department head, then assistant principal                 |      |       |              |
| 3  | He founded the Stock Market Club                                     |      |       |              |
| 4  | He brought in grant money to get computers into classrooms           |      |       |              |
| 5  | The Red Bank Register profiled him in 1987                           |      |       |              |
| 5a | Students walked out after the Rodney King verdict (April 1992)       |      |       |              |
| 5b | Vic led the students in prayer during the walkout                    |      |       |              |
| 5c | The Asbury Park Press published a photo of it                        |      |       |              |
| 5d | That photo is framed and hanging in the garage                       |      |       |              |
| 6  | The family had computers from ~1982 onward (Commodore, VIC-20, etc.) |      |       |              |

- 7 He retired from education in 2000
- 8 Yvonne taught health in Jersey City public schools
- 9 Yvonne retired in 2005

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

#### Tell Us a Story

**Dad:** What was the craziest thing a student ever did? The one you'd come home and tell Mom about, shaking your head? And was there one kid — one student over all those years — who made the whole career worth it?

**Mom:** Two educators under one roof. Did you compare notes at the dinner table? Was there a friendly rivalry over whose school was tougher?

## 4.3 Asbury Park School District

### Asbury Park: The City Behind the Music

**The wide lens:** Most people know Asbury Park from Springsteen's debut album. The reality was more complicated. By the time Vic arrived as a school administrator, Asbury Park had been through the **1970 Asbury Park riots** — four days of unrest that devastated the city's commercial district along Springwood Avenue. The boardwalk that Springsteen romanticized was surrounded by blocks of urban decay. The Stone Pony was playing to half-empty rooms. The population dropped from 17,000 in 1970 to under 16,000 by 1990.

**The school lens:** As an Abbott district, Asbury Park's schools were chronically underfunded relative to need. The student body was diverse, the challenges were real, and the stakes were high. Being an administrator here meant more than managing a building — it meant being a stabilizing presence in a community that was fighting to hold itself together.

**The close-up:** Vic chose to work here. A man from Bayonne's Italian-American neighborhoods, a Vietnam veteran, working in Asbury Park's public schools — it was service in the truest sense. The same commitment to healing that put him on medevac helicopters in Southeast Asia drove him to serve students in one of New Jersey's most challenged communities.

Victor went on to serve as **Assistant Principal at Asbury Park High School**, continuing his commitment to students across Monmouth County. Asbury Park — famous for its boardwalk, its music scene, and its complicated history of urban renewal — presented its own challenges and rewards for an educator committed to making a difference.

## 4.4 Shark River Hills and the Jersey Shore

While Vic was building schools, the family was building a life. Victor and Yvonne settled at **104 Highland Avenue in Shark River Hills** — an unincorporated community within **Neptune Township** — in 1980, and stayed for fifteen years before moving to **4 Rue de la Porte in Wall Township** in 1995. Both addresses sat in the heart of Monmouth County’s Jersey Shore corridor.

This wasn’t just geography. This was *identity*. The Shore defined the Cicconetti family’s daily life for decades:

- **Shark River Hills** — tucked along the Shark River inlet, a neighborhood of modest homes where you could smell the salt air and hear the gulls. The kind of place where kids rode bikes to the river and families knew their neighbors by name.
- **Wall Township** — where in **1995**, the Cicconettis built what Yvonne calls their “**5-bedroom, 5-bath palace**” at 253 Rue de la Porte. Good schools (Vic knew this better than anyone), safe streets, and easy access to the Shore. They’d earned every square foot.

The surrounding towns became the family’s stomping grounds: **Avon-by-the-Sea**, **Point Pleasant Beach**, and the boardwalk joints and seafood houses that define Shore life. These weren’t vacation destinations — they were the backdrop to daily life. Little League games, Sunday drives, summer evenings on the boardwalk.

And the restaurants — the places that became family institutions:

- **Pete & Elda’s** in Neptune City — the bar/restaurant where the thin-crust pizza has been a Shore institution since 1956. Every Shore family has their Pete & Elda’s stories.
- **Kelly’s Tavern** — cold drinks, good food, the kind of place where you run into everyone you know.

These were *the family’s places*. The spots where the Cicconettis gathered, celebrated, and lived the life that Vic had built from nothing — from a Bayonne row house to a Shore family raising kids in the salt air.

### **i** Your Turn — The Shore Years

**Dad & Mom:** What was the house in Shark River Hills like? How did you end up there? And Wall — what made you move?

**Rich and Greg:** What are your Shore memories? Beach days? Boardwalk nights? The first time you were allowed to go to Point Pleasant on your own? Pete & Elda’s — what’s your order?

**Everyone:** What’s the restaurant, the beach, the spot that IS the Cicconetti Jersey Shore? The place you’d take someone to show them what your family is about?

## 4.5 A New Church

But first, the church they *left*.

The Cicconettis were Catholic — cradle to confirmation, baptism to burial, the whole program. Assumption Church in Bayonne, CCD classes, Sunday Mass in your good clothes whether you wanted to or not. And for a while, the rhythm held. The kids went to grammar school through the parish system the way Italian-American kids did.

But somewhere around the time Rich finished grammar school, the family collectively — quietly, without any dramatic declaration — **stopped going**. No one nailed theses to the church door. There was no schism. They were just... done. The monotony of it. The same readings, the same responses, the same

kneeling and standing. Week after week after week. For a family as restless and forward-moving as the Cicconettis, the passive rhythm of the Catholic Mass had become wallpaper. They could recite it in their sleep, and that was exactly the problem.

But first — the church they *left*.

Now, the Cicconettis were Catholic. The whole deal. Cradle to confirmation, baptism to burial, CCD classes, Sunday Mass in your good clothes whether you felt like it or not. Assumption Church in Bayonne. You showed up. You knelt. You stood. You knelt again. You went home and ate dinner.

And then one day, sometime around when Rich finished grammar school, the whole family just... stopped. Nobody made a big announcement. There was no dramatic scene. They just stopped going. The monotony of it. Same readings. Same responses. Same kneeling, same standing, same everything, week after week after week. They could do the whole Mass in their sleep, and that was exactly the problem.

They weren't alone. Across America, the 1970s and '80s saw a quiet exodus from mainline churches — Catholic and Protestant alike. The cultural upheavals of the 1960s had loosened institutional religion's grip. Vatican II had modernized the Mass but confused the faithful. The Jesus Movement, charismatic Christianity, and evangelical megachurches were pulling Americans toward more personal, emotional worship experiences. The Catholic Church, with its hierarchy and ritual, felt to many families like their parents' religion — inherited, unexamined, going through the motions.

The Cicconettis were part of that wave. Not hostile to faith. Not atheists. Just *done with the format*.

And then Vic did something that nobody from Assumption Church in Bayonne would have predicted: he joined a **Baptist church** in Shark River Hills.

For a man raised in that Italian-American Catholic tradition — baptized, confirmed, married at the altar, Sunday Mass without question — walking into a Baptist congregation was a *move*. It wasn't rebellion. It wasn't rejection. It was Vic doing what Vic always does: **challenging himself**.

But there was more to it than spiritual curiosity. Vic had seen what unchecked habits could do to a man. His father, Victor Sr., had struggled with alcoholism — seriously, not casually. Vic grew up watching that. And when Vic looked at his own life — a Vietnam veteran, a school administrator, a father of three — he made a decision that took a different kind of courage than anything he'd done in Southeast Asia: **he decided to change**.

The Baptist church became a vehicle for that change. The structure, the community, the accountability, the discipline of studying scripture rather than just attending Mass out of habit — Vic used all of it. He wasn't running from Catholicism. He was running *toward* the man he wanted to be. The same man who chose to be a medic instead of a rifleman, who wrote grants for computers when other teachers were skeptical, who founded a veterans' chapter from scratch — that man decided to confront his own vulnerabilities head-on, in a room full of people who didn't share his last name or his neighborhood.

He didn't just attend. He **read the Bible cover to cover** — at least once, possibly twice. He **led youth groups** at the church. He committed. Fully.

And the kids? Greg hated it at the time. The teenage resistance to anything your father is enthusiastic about — multiplied by the awkwardness of switching religious traditions mid-childhood. But looking back, Greg sees it for what it was: his father refusing to coast. Refusing to inherit a faith — or a fate — without examining it. Deciding, in his forties, to *choose* rather than default. To break a cycle rather than repeat it.

Rich, on the other hand, was a **rock star**. The church ran a program called **Christian Crusaders** — a Baptist variant of Boy Scouts, with camping trips, outings, and the whole structure of youth leadership that scouting provides. Rich thrived in it. Completely at home. The same kid who would later build a

tech business and stay close to his parents in Galloway — that kid was already showing his character in Christian Crusaders, earning badges and leading campouts.

The faith journey — from Assumption Church to a Baptist congregation to the man who writes “the Lord has blessed you” in every milestone email — is its own kind of through line. Vic’s faith isn’t inherited. It’s *earned*. He did the reading. He did the work. He chose it.

Now think about this. A guy raised in that Italian-American Catholic tradition — baptized, confirmed, married at the altar, never missed a Sunday — and he walks into a *Baptist* church. In Shark River Hills. That’s a move. That’s not rebellion. That’s not rejection. That’s Vic doing what Vic always does: **challenging himself**.

But it wasn’t just spiritual curiosity. See, Vic had seen what happens when a man doesn’t deal with his demons. His father, Victor Sr., struggled with the drinking. Not casually — seriously. Vic grew up watching that. And somewhere in his forties, looking at his own life — Vietnam vet, school administrator, father — he made a decision that took more guts than anything he did in Southeast Asia: **he decided to change**.

The Baptist church was the vehicle. The structure. The community. The accountability. The discipline of actually *studying* scripture instead of just showing up and going through the motions. He used all of it. He wasn’t running from Catholicism. He was running *toward* the man he wanted to be.

And he didn’t half-ass it either. He **read the Bible cover to cover**. At least once. Maybe twice. He **led youth groups**. Full commitment.

The kids? Greg hated it. Classic teenager — anything your father’s excited about, you’re allergic to. But looking back, Greg sees it clearly: his father refused to coast. Refused to inherit a faith without examining it. Refused to inherit a fate without fighting it. In his forties, the man *chose*. That takes more courage than most people ever find.

Rich? Rich was a **rock star** in the church. They had this program, **Christian Crusaders** — like Baptist Boy Scouts, camping trips, the whole thing. Rich thrived. Completely at home. That kid who’d later build a business and stay close to his parents — he was already showing you who he was.

The faith journey — Assumption Church to Baptist congregation to the man who writes “the Lord has blessed you” in every email — that’s a through line as straight as anything in this story. Vic’s faith isn’t inherited. It’s *earned*. He did the reading. He did the work. He chose it.

 Check Our Work — Faith

| # | We wrote...                                      | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|--------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Vic joined a Baptist church in Shark River Hills |      |       |              |
| 2 | He read the Bible cover to cover (at least once) |      |       |              |
| 3 | He led youth groups at the church                |      |       |              |
| 4 | Rich was active in Christian Crusaders           |      |       |              |

Anything wrong? What was the church called? When did this start?

### Tell Us a Story — Faith

**Dad:** What made you walk into that Baptist church? Was there a moment, a person, a conversation? What did your mother Eleanor think? What did Yvonne think?

**Rich:** What do you remember about Christian Crusaders? Best camping trip? The thing that sticks with you?

**Greg:** You hated it at the time. What do you think about it now?

## 4.6 Retirement (2000)

After decades of service to New Jersey’s young people, Victor **retired in 2000**. His career had taken him through some of the state’s most dynamic school communities, and he left behind a legacy of dedication to public education.

### Saint Peter’s University Connection

Even in retirement, Victor maintained connections to education. A 2021 **Saint Peter’s University** commencement donor/honoree list includes his name — suggesting continued involvement with higher education and community even after stepping away from the daily work.

## 4.7 Two Educators Under One Roof

It’s worth noting that Victor’s career in education was shared with Yvonne’s. While he administered schools in Long Branch and Asbury Park, she taught health and coordinated programs in Jersey City. Together, they dedicated a combined **half-century** to New Jersey’s public school students — approaching education from different angles but with the same underlying commitment.

The son of Italian immigrants, who had served in Vietnam and come home to build a career in the classroom, was doing exactly what his parents’ generation had hoped for: turning the immigrant dream into American reality, one student at a time.

### Your Turn — Dad

We found the 1987 *Red Bank Register* article that called you “Man with Many Missions.” Do you remember that interview? Do you still have a copy?

- What made you go into education after Vietnam? Was it always the plan, or did it happen by accident?
- What was Long Branch High School like in the ’80s?
- Do you remember specific students who made it all worth it?
- What was a typical day like as an administrator?
- When you retired in 2000, what did you feel? Relief? Loss? Both?

**Mom:** You were teaching health in Jersey City while Dad was in Long Branch. Two educators under one roof — what was that like? Did you compare notes? Compete? Commiserate?



Figure 4.1: The Cicconetti family, 1974–75



Figure 4.2: Football season, 1974



Figure 4.3: The 1983–84 years



Figure 4.4: Triathlon, 1986

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*“Man with Many Missions.” The Red Bank Register got it right — and education was the mission that lasted the longest.*

## 5 The Family Table

*The Cicconetti love of food goes back to Collepietro. But it took an Italian restaurant in New Jersey to turn family tradition into a family business.*

### **i** Soundtrack: The Restaurant

Every Italian restaurant has a soundtrack. The kitchen runs on rhythm. The dining room runs on mood. This is what probably filled the Cicconetti restaurant:

**Kitchen & Dining Room** — *click any song to play*

- [Dean Martin](#) — “Ain’t That a Kick in the Head”
- [Louis Prima](#) — “Just a Gigolo” / [Louis Prima](#) — “Buona Sera” / [Louis Prima](#) — “Jump, Jive an’ Wail”
- [Frank Sinatra](#) — “New York, New York” / [Frank Sinatra](#) — “The Way You Look Tonight”
- [Tony Bennett](#) — “I Left My Heart in San Francisco” / [Tony Bennett](#) — “The Good Life”
- [Al Martino](#) — “Speak Softly Love” (*The Godfather theme* — *every Italian restaurant had it*)
- [Jerry Vale](#) — “Al Di La”
- [Connie Francis](#) — “Mama”
- [Rosemary Clooney](#) — “Mambo Italiano”
- [Harry Connick Jr.](#) — “It Had to Be You”
- [Michael Buble](#) — “Sway” / [Michael Buble](#) — “Feeling Good”

*What actually played in the restaurant? Did Dad have a favorite he’d put on repeat? Did the kitchen staff have a different playlist than the dining room? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (5 photos)

### **i** Italian-American Food: From Survival to Identity

**The wide lens:** When the first Italian immigrants arrived, they ate to survive — peasant food adapted to what was available in America. Olive oil was hard to find, so they used lard. They couldn’t get the specific greens from the old country, so they adapted recipes. Italian-American cooking — meatballs and spaghetti, chicken parmigiana, baked ziti — isn’t really “Italian food.” It’s the food of immigrants making do, then making it their own, then making it *legendary*.

By the 1970s and 80s, the Italian-American restaurant was an American institution. Every Jersey Shore town had at least one. The red-sauce joints, the pizza parlors, the “gravy” vs. “sauce” debates that could split a family. This was the food culture the Cicconettis lived and breathed.

**The Jersey lens:** New Jersey’s Italian food scene is arguably the best in America outside of New York City. From the tomato pie shops of Trenton to the pork stores of Newark’s Ironbound to the Shore restaurants in Long Branch, Belmar, and Point Pleasant — Italian food IS New Jersey food. When the Cicconettis opened their restaurant, they weren’t just starting a business. They were joining

a tradition as deep as the state itself.

## 5.1 An Italian Restaurant — A Family Venture

Victor's energy never stayed in one lane. He and Yvonne took their Italian heritage from the family kitchen to the business world, co-founding **Bistro-by-the-Sea G** in **Avon-by-the-Sea, NJ** with their son **Richard**. A family venture that combined food, hospitality, and the entrepreneurial spirit — three Cicconettis working side by side, turning heritage into a business.

The restaurant sat at **140 South Riverside Drive** along the **Shark River** — technically a Neptune mailing address, right on the border with Avon-by-the-Sea. A waterfront-adjacent spot in Monmouth County, just south of Asbury Park and Bradley Beach. Classic Jersey Shore territory where restaurants are as much a part of summer as the boardwalk.

Bistro-by-the-Sea was a **casual, family-friendly Italian spot** — pizza, Italian fare, affordable prices, and open from 6 AM through 9 PM. Breakfast through dinner, seven days a week. That's not a hobby. That's a family pouring everything they have into a business.

Running a restaurant is one of the most demanding small-business ventures there is. Long hours, tight margins, constant attention to quality and customer experience. Doing it as a family adds another layer — the intimacy of working alongside your spouse and your son, day after day, meal after meal.

Now, every Italian family thinks they can run a restaurant. Most of 'em are right. The Cicconettis? They didn't just think it. They did it. Vic, Yvonne, and their son Rich open **Bistro-by-the-Sea G** in **Avon-by-the-Sea, NJ**. A real family operation. Three Cicconettis, one kitchen, and the kind of energy that only comes from people who actually give a damn about what they're doing.

The place sits at **140 South Riverside Drive**, right on the **Shark River**. Technically it's a Neptune address, right on the border with Avon. Monmouth County. Just south of Asbury Park and Bradley Beach. Classic Jersey Shore. Down there, restaurants aren't just businesses — they're part of the landscape, like the boardwalk, like the salt air.

And this isn't some fancy white-tablecloth joint. Bistro-by-the-Sea is a **casual, family-friendly Italian spot**. Pizza. Italian fare. Prices that don't make you wince. Open from 6 AM to 9 PM. Breakfast through dinner. Seven days a week. You hear that? Seven days. That's not a side hustle. That's your whole life on a plate.

Here's what people don't understand about running a restaurant. It's the hardest small business there is. The hours are brutal. The margins are razor-thin. You gotta watch every detail — every plate, every customer, every penny. And when you're doing it with your wife and your kid? That's a whole other thing. You're not just coworkers. You're family. Every single day. Every single meal.

## 5.2 Food as Heritage

For Italian-American families, food is never just food. It's memory. It's identity. It's the thread that connects a grandmother's kitchen in the old country to a Sunday dinner table in New Jersey. The Cicconettis' restaurant venture was an expression of that heritage — a public declaration of who they were and where they came from.

See, with Italian families, food is never just food. It's everything. It's who you are. It's your grandmother's hands rolling dough in the old country. It's your mother's sauce on a Sunday in Jersey. It's the thread that

goes all the way back and all the way forward. When the Cicconettis open that restaurant, they’re not just making a living. They’re making a statement. This is who we are. This is where we come from. Sit down and eat.

 Check Our Work — The Restaurant

| # | We wrote...                                                                     | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Victor, Yvonne, and Richard co-founded Bistro-by-the-Sea in Avon-by-the-Sea, NJ |      |       |              |

**TRUE or FALSE? And fill in what we’re missing:**

 Tell Us a Story

**Dad & Mom:** We know it was Bistro-by-the-Sea in Avon. Now tell us the rest. What was the dish people drove across town for? What’s the funniest thing that happened in that kitchen? Who burned what? Who cried? Was there a regular customer you still remember by name? What years did it run?

**Rich:** What was it like working with your parents every single day? What’s the one story from Bistro-by-the-Sea that you always tell?

### 5.3 The Elia Side: Mary Ann’s Pizza Bistro

The entrepreneurial food spirit ran on both sides of the family — and in fact, Bistro-by-the-Sea was **a riff off an Elia original**. Yvonne’s sister **Mary Ann Hurley** (nee Elia) ran a **Pizza Bistro in Bayonne** — keeping the Italian-American food tradition alive in the neighborhood where she and Yvonne grew up. When the Cicconettis opened their own place at the Shore, they took the “Bistro” name and ran with it: **Bistro-by-the-Sea**.

Two sisters. Two “Bistros.” Two families carrying the same tradition forward — one in Bayonne, one at the Shore. The dinner table was always at the center.

But here’s the thing — the Cicconettis weren’t even the first ones in the family to do it. Yvonne’s sister **Mary Ann Hurley** — she was an Elia before she got married — she’s already running a **Pizza Bistro back in Bayonne**. Right there in the old neighborhood. So when Vic and Yvonne open their place at the Shore, what do they call it? **Bistro-by-the-Sea**. They take the name and run with it. It’s beautiful when you think about it.

Two sisters. Two Bistros. One in Bayonne, one at the Shore. Two families, same tradition, same table. Just a longer drive between ’em.

## **i** Your Turn — This Chapter Is Almost Empty Without You

We know you founded Bistro-by-the-Sea in Avon-by-the-Sea. Now we need the stories. This chapter needs YOU more than any other.

### **Dad & Mom:**

- What years did Bistro-by-the-Sea operate?
- Whose idea was it? How did it start?
- What were the signature dishes? What was the thing people came back for?
- What was the best night? The worst night?
- What did you learn about each other from working together?

**Rich:** What was it like working with your parents every day? What's the story you tell people when they ask about Bistro-by-the-Sea?

**Aunt Mary Ann:** What was your pizza bistro called? Was there a friendly rivalry between the two family restaurants?

*An Italian-American family that runs a restaurant together — this chapter should practically write itself. But only if you talk.*



Figure 5.1: Bistro-by-the-Sea, exterior



Figure 5.2: Inside the restaurant



Figure 5.3: The Bistro kitchen



Figure 5.4: Bistro-by-the-Sea

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*Not every family turns their heritage into a business. The Cicconettis did — and the family table got a whole lot bigger.*

*Most families just eat together. The Cicconettis? They fed the whole town. And the family table? It got a whole lot bigger.*

## **Part III**

# **Part III: The Man He Became**

## 6 Serving Those Who Served

Victor forwarded “The Gift of Time” — a parable about Alexander the Great’s deathbed wishes — to his sons and his brother-in-law. The lesson: time is the most precious gift. Vic lives that lesson through the time he gives to fellow veterans.

### **i** Soundtrack: Brotherhood

The songs that veterans carry with them — some from the war, some from the homecoming, some from the long road of making sense of it all:

**Service & Homecoming** — *click any song to play*

- [Bruce Springsteen](#) — “Born in the U.S.A.” (*the most misunderstood song in America — it’s not a celebration, it’s a reckoning*)
- [Dire Straits](#) — “Brothers in Arms”
- [Johnny Cash](#) — “Ragged Old Flag”
- [Lee Greenwood](#) — “God Bless the U.S.A.”
- [Simon & Garfunkel](#) — “The Sound of Silence” / [Simon & Garfunkel](#) — “Bridge Over Troubled Water”
- [Bob Dylan](#) — “Blowin’ in the Wind”
- [Edwin Starr](#) — “War” (*what is it good for?*)
- [Marvin Gaye](#) — “What’s Going On”
- [Bruce Springsteen](#) — “The Rising”
- [Billy Joel](#) — “Goodnight Saigon” (*and we would all go down together*)

*Veterans of Chapter 12 — what song hits different when you’re with the guys? Dad — is there a song that takes you back? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (6 photos)

#### **i** The Long Road to Recognition: Vietnam Veterans in America

**The wide lens:** Vietnam veterans came home to a country that didn’t want to look at them. No parades. No ticker tape. Many were spat on, called baby killers, told to take off the uniform. The government that sent them to war treated them as a political embarrassment. Agent Orange exposure was denied for decades. PTSD wasn’t even recognized as a diagnosis until **1980** — eleven years after the last troops came home.

The numbers were staggering: **58,220 Americans killed**. Over **300,000 wounded**. An estimated **700,000** veterans suffering from PTSD. And for years, the country looked away.

**The turning point:** On **November 13, 1982**, the **Vietnam Veterans Memorial** was dedicated on the National Mall — Maya Lin’s black granite wall inscribed with every name. Tens of thousands of veterans gathered in Washington. Many wept openly. For the first time, the country was saying: *we see you*.

That same year, the **Vietnam Veterans of America** was officially chartered by Congress. Chapters began forming across the country — grassroots organizations built by the veterans themselves, for themselves. No one was going to advocate for them if they didn't do it themselves.

**The New Jersey lens:** New Jersey sent over **170,000 men and women** to Vietnam — one of the highest per-capita rates in the nation. The state's working-class cities — Bayonne, Newark, Jersey City, Paterson, Trenton — bore the heaviest burden. By the 1980s, NJ veterans were organizing, forming VVA chapters, pushing for recognition and services. The **New Jersey Vietnam Veterans' Memorial** in Holmdel was dedicated in **1995** — a 200-foot-long black granite wall overlooking the Garden State Parkway.

**The close-up:** This is where Vic stepped in. He didn't wait for someone else to build it. He helped found **VVA Chapter 12** in Ocean Township — creating, from scratch, the community that the country had failed to provide. The medic who healed in Vietnam was still healing at home.

## 6.1 Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter 12

Victor's deepest community commitment has been to his fellow veterans. As a **founding member and president of Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter 12** in Ocean Township, NJ, he helped build an organization dedicated to the men and women who served in Vietnam.

The founding of VVA Chapter 12 was a natural extension of Victor's character: the same man who flew medical evacuations to save lives in Southeast Asia continued serving his fellow veterans at home. It was not enough to have served; Victor felt a duty to make sure that those who served alongside him were never forgotten.

VVA Chapter 12 was — and remains — part of a national movement to ensure that Vietnam-era veterans are:

- **Recognized** for their service and sacrifice
- **Supported** with resources, advocacy, and practical assistance
- **Connected** to a community that understands their experience

The chapter gave veterans something that was in short supply when they came home from Vietnam: a place where their service was honored, their experiences were understood, and their needs were advocated for.

## 6.2 Life Memberships

Victor holds **life memberships** in:

- **Veterans Affairs (VA)**
- **Disabled American Veterans (DAV)**

These are not honorary titles. They reflect decades of active participation in the veteran community — showing up, advocating, and giving time to the cause that mattered most to him beyond family.

## Check Our Work — Veterans

| # | We wrote...                                                      | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Victor was a founding member of VVA Chapter 12 in Ocean Township |      |       |              |
| 2 | He served as president of Chapter 12                             |      |       |              |
| 3 | He is a life member of the VA                                    |      |       |              |
| 4 | He is a life member of the DAV                                   |      |       |              |

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

## Tell Us a Story

**Dad:** What was the first Chapter 12 meeting like? Was it in someone's living room? A VFW hall? A bar? Who showed up, and what made you think *"this is something real"*?

**Fellow veterans:** What's the Vic Cicconetti story you tell when he's not in the room? The one that captures who he really is as a leader and a friend?

## 6.3 The Parade

Vic was active in **Vietnam veteran parades** — marching with his brothers from VVA Chapter 12, in formation, with pride. For a generation that came home to silence, every parade was a reclamation. Every step said: *we served, we're here, and we're not ashamed.*

But there's one parade image that captures something deeper than veteran pride. Picture this:

**Victor Cicconetti, Vietnam veteran, marching with his fellow vets** — and in the same parade, in a different formation, **his sons marching in NJROTC uniforms** with the **Marine Academy of Science and Technology (MAST)**.

MAST — the elite magnet school at Sandy Hook, part of the Monmouth County Vocational School District — combined rigorous STEM academics with Naval ROTC discipline. The Cicconetti boys were there, in uniform, marching in the same parade as their father.

Think about what Vic saw when he looked across that parade route: his own journey reflected back at him. A Vietnam veteran medic who came home and built a life — and now his sons, in uniform, getting the education and discipline that would launch them into their own careers. The immigrant bet, compounding again. Three generations from Collepietro to NJROTC dress whites.

That was a point of pride that went beyond the parade. That was the whole project — the whole family mission — made visible in a single afternoon on a Jersey Shore boulevard.

### i Check Our Work — Parades & MAST

| # | We wrote...                                                            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Vic marched in Vietnam veteran parades                                 |      |       |              |
| 2 | Rich and Greg attended MAST (Marine Academy of Science and Technology) |      |       |              |
| 3 | The sons marched in NJROTC in the same parades as Vic                  |      |       |              |

**Anything wrong? Which parades? What years? Who else was there?**

## 6.4 The Forward Network

Vic's veteran connections show up in the most personal places. His email forward list — the circle of people he shares life wisdom with — includes fellow veterans and Bayonne-era friends: Leon, David Connelly, Larry Messina, and others. These are the men he sends chain emails about life philosophy, the Gift of Time, and the things that matter.

In November 2015, Vic forwarded to Greg, Rich, and Mike Hurley a parable about Alexander the Great's dying wishes — the message being that worldly achievements pale next to the gift of time well spent. That's the kind of thing Vic curates and shares: not just jokes or politics, but *meaning*.

His veteran circle is his brotherhood. For Vic, the uniform came off in 1969, but the bond of service never did.

### i Your Turn — Dad

You founded VVA Chapter 12. We don't know when, and we don't know the full story.

- What year did you start the chapter? What pushed you to do it?
- Who were the other founders? Are any of them still around?
- What were the chapter's biggest accomplishments?
- Is Chapter 12 still active?
- What does veteran advocacy mean to you — really? Not the official version. The personal one.

**Fellow veterans — Leon, David Connelly, Larry Messina, and the rest of the forward list:** If you're reading this, Vic doesn't know about this book. What would you want to say about him? What kind of leader was he? Send your stories — they'll go right into this chapter.



Figure 6.1: Veterans gathering



Figure 6.2: With fellow veterans



Figure 6.3: Veterans event



Figure 6.4: VVA gathering

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*Victor's commitment to his fellow veterans is the thread that runs through his entire adult life — from the medevac flights of his twenties to the advocacy work of his seventies. It is, perhaps, his longest-running mission.*

## 7 Family Man

*“Look at yourselves!!!!”* — Vic, sending a family photo to his sons and granddaughter, September 2017. Four exclamation marks. No body text needed.

### **i** Soundtrack: The Cicconetti House

Every family has songs that ARE the family — the ones that trigger memories the moment you hear the first three notes:

**Songs for a Family Man** — *click any song to play*

- Cat Stevens — “Father and Son”
- Jim Croce — “Time in a Bottle”
- Stevie Wonder — “Isn’t She Lovely”
- Louis Armstrong — “What a Wonderful World”
- Van Morrison — “Brown Eyed Girl”
- The Temptations — “My Girl”
- Billy Joel — “Lullabye (Goodnight, My Angel)”
- Harry Chapin — “Cat’s in the Cradle” (*every dad’s gut-punch*)
- Bruce Springsteen — “Waitin’ on a Sunny Day”
- Nat King Cole — “Unforgettable”

*What’s the song that IS the Cicconetti family? The one Dad plays every holiday? The one that makes Mom roll her eyes? The one the grandkids associate with Grandpa’s house? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (31 photos)

### **i** The Italian-American Family: A Different Kind of Institution

**The wide lens:** The Italian-American family was never just a family — it was a *system*. A social safety net, an employment agency, a marriage bureau, a banking institution, and a tribunal of justice rolled into one. In the old country, the *famiglia* was the only institution that mattered — the government was distant, the Church was powerful but abstract, and the *padrone* exploited you. Your family fed you, housed you, and protected you.

When Italians came to America, they brought this system with them. Sunday dinners weren’t optional. Family decisions were collective. You didn’t move away without a reason everyone could accept. You married someone the family approved of (or you eloped and dealt with the consequences). You named your children after your parents and grandparents — a chain of names linking the generations.

By the time Vic and Yvonne were raising their family in the 1970s and 80s, the old-country strictness had softened, but the core values held: **loyalty, proximity, showing up**. The Cicconetti family — two educators, two sons, Shore living — was the Italian-American dream fully realized. Not wealth, but stability. Not fame, but respect. Not distance, but closeness.

## 7.1 Two Sons, Three Grandchildren

At the center of Victor’s life is family. He and Yvonne raised **two sons** — Greg and Rich — in a household shaped by two educators, Italian-American values, and the quiet strength of parents who had built their lives from scratch.

### Greg Cicconetti

Greg — the eldest — earned a Ph.D. from the University of Connecticut, held a faculty position at Muhlenberg College, spent a decade at GSK, and became a Research Fellow at AbbVie. The son of a public school administrator and a health teacher built a career in clinical statistics and drug development. Greg has two children: **Ellie Wexler** and **Anthony John Cicconetti**.

### Richard Victor Cicconetti

Rich studied at **Rutgers University** and has built a career in technology, specializing in form-building solutions through his business, **Cicco Devel**. He and his wife **Sharon** (nee Doughty) live in Galloway, NJ — close to Victor and Yvonne, keeping the family geography tight. Rich represents the next generation: rooted in New Jersey, connected to family, and building something of his own. Rich has one son: **Richard Victor Cicconetti Jr.**, known as **Richie**.

Sharon joined the family as Sharon Katherine Doughty. Her father, **Clarence S. “Clancy” Doughty, Jr.**, passed away in July 2024 — a recent loss the family felt deeply.

### The Grandchildren

Victor and Yvonne have three biological grandchildren:

- **Ellie Wexler** (Greg’s daughter)
- **Anthony John Cicconetti** (Greg’s son)
- **Richard Victor Cicconetti Jr. “Richie”** (Rich’s son)

## 7.2 The Coach, the Ref, and the Thumb on the Scale

Vic coached soccer. He was *in it* — organizing practices, running drills, doing the thing that dads in Shore communities did on Saturday mornings. He loved it.

Greg did not love it. Greg did not love any of it.

The Greg Cicconetti athletic career is a highlight reel of heroic disinterest:

- **Baseball:** Famous for doing cartwheels in the outfield and kicking dandelions while the game happened around him. The uniforms were itchy. The whole enterprise was suspect.
- **Soccer:** The only goal Greg ever scored was in **kindergarten** — and it was against his own team. Career shooting percentage: technically perfect, if you don’t ask which net.
- **Basketball:** Lasted exactly one session. There was no second session.

Vic, the former “Glue Fingers” of Bayonne high school football, watched all of this and did not give up. That’s its own kind of parenting — the athlete father who keeps showing up for the kid who is never going to be an athlete, without making the kid feel like a failure for it.

## The Marksman Medal

But the rifle team — that’s where the story gets complicated, and real, and *Vic*.

Greg was on the rifle team. Vic was there as **parent support** — involved, present, doing the behind-the-scenes work that makes youth programs run. At a competition, Greg’s score came in **just shy of making marksman**. One point short.

And Vic — the rule-follower, the school administrator, the man who built his career on institutional trust — **bumped the score by a point**. He pushed his son across the line.

Greg hated it. He didn’t want to cheat. He knew the score was wrong. But in that moment, standing there with a medal he hadn’t quite earned, Greg also understood something fundamental about his father: **Vic breaks rules to advance people**. Not for himself — for *other people*. His son. His students. The kid across the street. If someone was one point short, one step behind, one push away from making it — Vic would provide the push. Every time. Without hesitation.

Greg wore the medal without a second thought. Not because the score was right, but because the man behind it was.

## The Pusher

That instinct — *I will get you across the finish line* — is the thread that runs through everything Vic did as a father:

- He pushed **Rich** across the finish line with his schooling — the kind of sustained, daily, unglamorous parental pressure that doesn’t make the highlight reel but makes the diploma possible.
- He helped **Yvonne** when she went back to advance her teaching credentials — supporting her education the same way he supported his students’, because the unspoken rule applied to everyone under his roof. Everyone advances. No exceptions.
- He pushed his students at Long Branch — the grants for computers, the Stock Market Club, the extra effort that turned a business department into a launchpad.

This is the core of Vic’s character, and it’s more nuanced than “proud dad.” He’s not just proud of his children’s accomplishments. He’s *in the engine room* of those accomplishments, pushing, adjusting, occasionally bending a rule when the rule is the only thing standing between someone he loves and the thing they deserve.

Is it always by the book? No. But the man who flew medevac in Vietnam didn’t learn his ethics from a book. He learned them from the conviction that **you do whatever it takes to get your people home safe** — and “home safe” includes a marksman medal, a diploma, a teaching credential, and a career.

## 7.3 The Proud Dad

Vic’s emails to his children reveal a father who is present, emotional, and endlessly proud. When Greg shared career milestones — a promotion at GSK, the AbbVie offer, the Research Fellow announcement — Vic responded immediately, warmly, and with his whole heart:

“Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!! Congratulations for a job well done. I hope it satisfied all your expectations. It looks like a great start. The Lord has blessed you once more. Here’s a big hug and a kiss.”

That’s Vic: faith, pride, physical affection, and exclamation marks. In the same email, he mentioned his aunt Yolanda had just died — mixing family joy with family grief in the same breath. That’s a man who carries it all.

When Greg was promoted to Research Fellow at AbbVie in 2018, the company-wide announcement — detailing a Ph.D. from the University of Connecticut, a faculty position at Muhlenberg College, a decade at GSK, and pioneering work in clinical statistics — was forwarded straight to Mom and Dad. The son of a public school administrator and a health teacher had become a Research Fellow in drug development. And the first people he told were his parents.

## 7.4 “Look at yourselves!!!!”

In September 2017, Vic sent a family photo (P1020477.JPG) to Rich, Ellie, and Greg. The subject line: **“Look at yourselves!!!!”** The body: empty. Four exclamation marks said everything.

That’s the proud father and grandfather. The man who looks at his family and can barely contain the joy.

| i Check Our Work — Family |                                                                   |      |       |              |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| #                         | We wrote...                                                       | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
| 1                         | Victor and Yvonne have two sons (Greg and Rich)                   |      |       |              |
| 2                         | Rich was born approximately August 1977                           |      |       |              |
| 3                         | Rich attended Rutgers University                                  |      |       |              |
| 4                         | Rich married Sharon K. Doughty                                    |      |       |              |
| 5                         | They have three biological grandchildren (Ellie, Anthony, Richie) |      |       |              |
| 6                         | Vic coached soccer                                                |      |       |              |
| 7                         | Greg’s only soccer goal was against his own team (kindergarten)   |      |       |              |

- 8 Greg lasted one session  
of basketball
- 9 Vic was rifle team  
parent support
- 10 Vic helped Yvonne  
advance her teaching  
credentials

**Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:**

### Tell Us a Story

**Rich and Greg:** What's the most trouble you got into as kids that you DEFINITELY didn't tell Mom and Dad about at the time? And what's the thing Dad did that was SO embarrassing when you were teenagers but now makes you laugh until you cry?

**Ellie, Anthony, and Richie:** What's the funniest thing Grandpa has ever said? The joke he tells every single time? The face he makes? Don't overthink it — just the first thing that pops into your head.

## 7.5 The Health Kick

There was a phase — and it was glorious.

Vic and Eve (the family's name for Yvonne) got into **running**. Not jogging-around-the-block running. *Running* running. The kind where you buy the shoes, track the miles, and talk about it at dinner. The health kick swept through the extended family like a fever:

- **Mike Hurley Sr.** and his kids were deep into **weights, martial arts, and aerobics**. The Hurley household was a gym before it was a house.
- **Mike Hurley Jr.** played **football** in school — carrying on the athletic tradition that his uncle Vic had started as “Glue Fingers” in Bayonne.
- **Kathy Pacifico** (Mike and Mary Ann's daughter) turned the family's fitness obsession into a business: **Forum Fitness Club** in Bayonne, which she has run since **1982**. The Elia-Hurley side didn't just exercise — they *institutionalized* exercise.

And the Cicconettis? They went bigger. Vic and Eve organized **family reunion triathlons** — events that brought the whole clan together for swimming, biking, and running. Not professionally. Not competitively (well, maybe a little competitively). But together. Because for this family, even fitness was a group activity. Even a triathlon was a family reunion.

The health kick was real. It was part of the Shore years, part of the fitness culture of the 1980s and '90s, part of two families — Cicconetti and Hurley — that believed in pushing themselves physically the same way they pushed themselves professionally.

## i Check Our Work — The Health Kick

| # | We wrote...                                               | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Vic and Yvonne got into running                           |      |       |              |
| 2 | They organized family reunion triathlons                  |      |       |              |
| 3 | The Hurleys were into weights, martial arts, and aerobics |      |       |              |
| 4 | Mike Hurley Jr. played football in school                 |      |       |              |

**When was this? What were the triathlons like? Who won?**

## i The Fads, the Trends, and the Things That Stuck (1960s–2000s)

**Every decade brought its fashions, its obsessions, and its cultural moments. The Cicconettis lived through all of them:**

**The 1960s** — Bell-bottoms, tie-dye, the British Invasion, muscle cars, and the space race. *The Flintstones* was primetime television. The family watched the moon landing on a black-and-white TV — every American did. JFK's assassination. The Beatles on Ed Sullivan. Woodstock (though Bayonne Italians were not exactly the Woodstock demographic).

**The 1970s** — Disco, leisure suits, the pet rock, mood rings, and the energy crisis. Gas lines. Watergate on television every night. *Star Wars* changed everything in 1977. The Bee Gees were inescapable. Every neighborhood had a kid with a skateboard and a kid with a CB radio. Earth shoes. Macramé plant hangers. The Brady Bunch as aspirational family life.

**The 1980s** — Aerobics, leg warmers, Members Only jackets, Pac-Man, the Walkman, and MTV. Reagan was president and the Berlin Wall came down. *E.T.* made every kid want a bike with a basket. Cabbage Patch Kids caused actual fistfights in stores. The Rubik's Cube. Atari, then Nintendo. Hair got bigger. Shoulder pads got bigger. The fitness craze hit hard — Jane Fonda tapes, Jazzercise, running became a lifestyle, not just exercise. The Cicconettis and Hurleys caught this wave fully.

**The 1990s** — Grunge killed hair metal. Beanie Babies became investment vehicles (they weren't). The Macarena. Fanny packs. Rollerblades. *Seinfeld* and *Friends* defined the decade. The internet arrived — slowly, then all at once. AOL dial-up. "You've got mail." The Y2K panic. Everyone bought a cell phone the size of a brick and felt like James Bond.

**The 2000s** — Reality TV took over (*Survivor*, *American Idol*, *Jersey Shore* — *yes, Jersey Shore*). Facebook launched. The iPhone arrived in 2007 and nothing was ever the same. Crocs. Low-rise jeans. The housing boom, then the crash. Everyone got a GPS and stopped asking for directions. DVDs replaced VHS, then streaming replaced DVDs.

**What stuck:** Through every fad that came and went — pet rocks, Beanie Babies, fidget spinners — the things that lasted in the Cicconetti household were the things that mattered: family dinners, Shore trips, faith, and the belief that you show up for the people you love. The leisure suits went to Goodwill. The family stayed.

## 7.6 The Family Circle

The Cicconetti family orbit extends beyond the immediate household:

- **Rich's wedding** at Ram's Head Inn (rehearsal January 2018) brought together the core family

- **The 40th anniversary** in 2007 was a family reunion at the Hurley home in Stafford
- **The 75th birthday** in 2021 was coordinated by Kathy Pacifico with a tribute video
- **The 80th birthday** in 2026 — this celebration — brings the circle together again

And through it all, the sign-off never changes:

Love DAD

### **i** Your Turn — Everyone

**Rich and Greg:** What's your best Vic story? The one you tell at parties. The one that makes people say "your dad sounds amazing." Write it down — even just a few sentences. It goes straight into this chapter.

**The grandkids:** What's the thing Grandpa always says? What's his best joke? What does he do that cracks you up? What's the thing about him that you'll remember when you're old?

**Everyone:** What are the Vic-isms? The phrases he uses, the habits, the things that are just *so Dad/Grandpa*?

*We already know he signs every email "Love DAD." What else?*

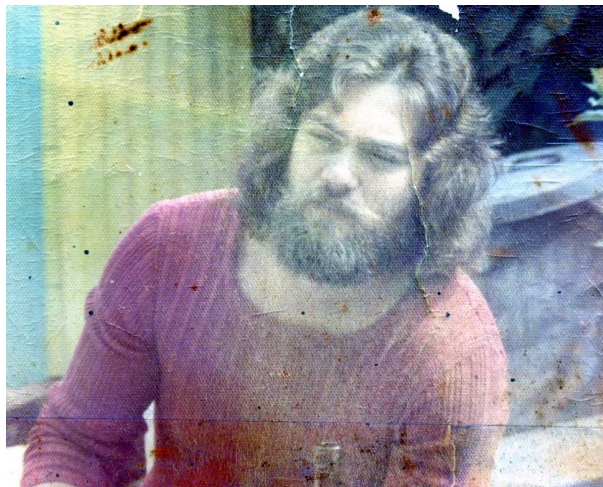


Figure 7.1: August 1971 — the young family



Figure 7.2: “Have tent, will camp” — Summer 1979



Figure 7.3: Mother’s Day, 1986



Figure 7.4: Summer of 1987



Figure 7.5: November 1990



Figure 7.6: Mom & Dad vacation, 1996



Figure 7.7: “Look at yourselves!!!!” — September 2017



Figure 7.8: Dad

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*Three grandchildren. Two sons. Nearly sixty years of marriage. The numbers tell the story of a man whose greatest achievement has always been family.*

## 8 “Love DAD”

*“Greg do you think you could purchase this pistol for me for target practice, I would like some ammo as well. Let me know. Love DAD” — Vic, age 75, shopping for an air pistol via email*

### **i** Soundtrack: Still Rocking at 80 (2000s–Today)

At 80, Vic’s still going. Still shopping for air pistols, still hitting AC, still signing every email “Love DAD.” Here’s the soundtrack for a man who earned every note:

**The Victory Lap** — *click any song to play*

- [Frank Sinatra — “My Way”](#) (*the only possible closer*)
- [Dean Martin — “Ain’t That a Kick in the Head”](#)
- [Bruce Springsteen — “Land of Hope and Dreams”](#) / [Bruce Springsteen — “No Surrender”](#)
- [Journey — “Don’t Stop Believin”](#)
- [Queen — “We Are the Champions”](#)
- [Neil Diamond — “Sweet Caroline”](#)
- [Frank Sinatra — “Young at Heart”](#)
- [Bob Seger — “Like a Rock”](#)
- [The Four Seasons — “December, 1963 \(Oh, What a Night\)”](#)
- [Frank Sinatra — “The Best Is Yet to Come”](#)

*What does Dad actually listen to these days? What station is the car radio stuck on? What song does he sing in the shower? [Suggest a song](#) → — we’ll add the best suggestions to the final playlist.*

### **i** Photo Gallery (25 photos)

### **i** The World Since Retirement (2000–2026)

**The wide lens:** Vic retired into a century that started with a shock. On **September 11, 2001** — just a year into his retirement — the Twin Towers fell. From New Jersey’s shoreline, you could see the smoke rising from Lower Manhattan. The Pentagon was hit. A plane went down in Pennsylvania. For a Vietnam veteran watching from across the harbor, it was a new kind of war — and this one was hitting home.

Then came the wars that followed: Afghanistan (2001–2021), Iraq (2003–2011). A Vietnam veteran watching a new generation of young Americans shipped overseas. The financial crisis of **2008** — the Great Recession, the worst economic collapse since the Depression. And then **COVID-19** in **2020** — a pandemic that locked the country down, separated families, and killed over a million Americans. Vic was 74 when the pandemic hit. For a man whose life was built on family proximity and gathering, the isolation was its own kind of hardship.

**The Jersey lens:** **Superstorm Sandy** slammed into the Jersey Shore on **October 29, 2012**, devastating the boardwalks, beach towns, and communities that had been the Cicconetti family’s world for decades. Seaside Heights’ boardwalk — an icon of Shore culture — burned. Homes along

the coast were destroyed. Point Pleasant, Avon, Belmar — all of them took hits. The Shore rebuilt, because that's what the Shore does. But the families who lived through Sandy never forgot.

**The close-up:** Through all of it — 9/11, two wars, a financial crisis, a superstorm, a pandemic — Vic and Yvonne held steady. The same partnership that had weathered Vietnam, career building, and child-rearing now weathered the disruptions of the new century. Still together. Still going to AC. Still signing every email “Love DAD.”

## **i** When the Shore Fought Back: Hurricanes & the Cicconetti Houses

The Jersey Shore isn't just boardwalks and pizza. It's a coastline that gets hammered — and the Cicconettis lived through every major hit.

### **The storms that shaped Shore life:**

- **1944 — Great Atlantic Hurricane:** Made landfall near Atlantic City as a Category 1. Ripped boardwalks apart from Cape May to Long Branch. This was the storm the old-timers talked about when Vic was growing up.
- **1954 — Hurricane Carol:** Tracked just offshore. 65 dead along the East Coast. Every Shore family knew someone who lost a boat, a dock, a summer.
- **1960 — Hurricane Donna:** The only hurricane in recorded history to produce hurricane-force winds in Florida, the Mid-Atlantic, *and* New England in a single pass. Heavy flooding across NJ.
- **1971 — Hurricane Doria:** Made landfall near Atlantic City. Here's where it gets personal: **Shark River Hills flooded badly.** The tidal river backed up, basements filled, streets turned to canals. The house at **104 Highland Ave** — where Vic and Yvonne would move in 1980 — took its first hit.
- **1985 — Hurricane Gloria:** Category 1 at NJ. Vic was running Long Branch schools. Mandatory evacuations along the Shore. \$900 million in damage. School closures, emergency shelters in the gyms, the whole district mobilized.
- **1991 — “The Perfect Storm”:** The Halloween Nor'easter. 30-foot waves. Coastal flooding from Cape May to Sandy Hook. Not technically a hurricane, but it didn't need a name to destroy.
- **2011 — Hurricane Irene:** Category 1 but *massive*. Shark River Hills flooded again — **104 Highland Ave took its second hit.** Ten deaths in NJ. The rivers couldn't handle the rain.
- **2012 — Superstorm Sandy:** The big one. Made landfall at Brigantine. 37 dead in NJ. \$30 billion in damage. Seaside Heights' boardwalk burned. Point Pleasant, Avon, Belmar — all devastated. The Shore rebuilt, because that's what the Shore does. But nobody who lived through Sandy ever forgot it.
- **2021 — Hurricane Ida (remnants):** Not even a hurricane anymore by the time it reached NJ, but the remnants dumped catastrophic rain. 30 dead. Tornado in Mullica Hill. Neptune flooded. **18 Waterview Court** — the house Vic and Yvonne had lived in for two decades — was in the flood zone again.

**The personal cost:** Vic and Yvonne's houses didn't just *weather* these storms — they were in the crosshairs. Shark River Hills sits where the Shark River meets tidal marshes. When a storm pushes water inland, Highland Ave is one of the first to flood. They lived there for 15 years (1980–1995), through Gloria, through the Perfect Storm, through nor'easters that don't make the history books but still put water in your basement.

Then Neptune — 18 Waterview Court — same story, different river. The name tells you everything: *Waterview*. Beautiful on a calm day. Terrifying when Ida's remnants dump eight inches of rain in three hours.

The Shore families don't leave. They sandbag, they pump, they gut the drywall, they rebuild. And then they go back to Pete & Elda's and order a thin-crust pizza like nothing happened. That's the deal.

*Interactive hurricane map available in the online version.*

## 8.1 Retirement, Jersey-Style

When Victor retired from public school administration in 2000, he didn't slow down. He and Yvonne settled at **18 Waterview Court in Neptune** — still Shore country, still close to the places where they'd raised their family — **104 Highland Ave in Shark River Hills** (1980–1995) and **4 Rue de la Porte in Wall** (1995–2000). They lived in Neptune for two decades before moving south in 2020 to **671 Cypress Point Drive at Blue Heron Pines** in Egg Harbor City — a golf community in Atlantic County, near the Pine Barrens and the Shore, a quieter life but never a dull one.

The year 2000 rolls around and Vic retires from the school system. And does he slow down? Does he sit on the couch? He does not. He moves to **18 Waterview Court in Neptune** — still Shore country, still close to everything — after twenty years in Shark River Hills and five in Wall. They stay in Neptune for two decades before heading south to **Blue Heron Pines** in Egg Harbor City. A golf community. Near the Pine Barrens. Near AC. A quieter life, but trust me — never a dull one.

Retirement for Vic has meant:

- **Atlantic City trips** — multiple references in his emails to “going to AC wed & thurs.” The casinos, the boardwalk, the restaurants. It's part of the NJ retirement lifestyle, and Vic and Yvonne are regulars. And AC has delivered its share of stories — including the time Vic **shook hands with O.J. Simpson** at a fight in Atlantic City. Yes, *that* O.J. The kind of random, only-in-AC celebrity encounter that becomes a family story told at every gathering for the next thirty years. Vic was there. O.J. was there. Hands were shaken. The family has opinions.
- **The grandchildren** — four of them now, each carrying the family forward: **Ellie Cicconetti** (October 2, 2004), **Anthony Cicconetti** (July 25, 2009), **Richard Cicconetti Jr.** (July 20, 2011), and **Jessie Leeks** (June 4, 1994). The proud grandpa who sent “Look at yourselves!!!!” with four exclamation marks and no body text — that's Vic, watching the immigrant bet compound into a fourth generation.
- **Target practice at 75** — In September 2021, Vic forwarded a Heartland America ad for a **Beeman Sportsman Deluxe Air Pistol** (\$49.99, .177 caliber) and asked Greg to order it. At seventy-five, Vic was still shooting, still active, still keeping his edge. The casual “Love DAD” sign-off on a request for ammunition is peak Vic.
- **The daily briefing** — Vic stays engaged with the world. **Fox News** is the soundtrack of the house. **Mark Levin** is the voice on the radio. He and Yvonne watch, listen, debate, and form opinions — together, always together. They are not passive consumers. They are citizens who care deeply about the direction of their country, informed by a lifetime of experience that runs from Vietnam to the present.
- **Wisdom curator** — Vic forwards emails to his sons and brother-in-law Mike Hurley about life philosophy, faith, humor, and politics. He doesn't just consume this content — he *curates* it, selecting messages he believes carry real meaning and sharing them with the people he loves. The “Gift of Time” parable about Alexander the Great. Patriotic stories. Inspirational messages. Political commentary. Life lessons. Vic sees himself as passing wisdom — and conviction — to the next generation. The

forward list is his broadcast network, and the signal is always the same: *this matters, and I want you to see it.*

## 8.2 The World That Changed Around Him

### **i** 80 Years of Everyday Things

**Technology didn't just change in Vic's lifetime — it changed *everything*, over and over, and he lived through every transition:**

**In the kitchen:** The icebox became a refrigerator. The wringer washer became an automatic. The dish-drying rack became a dishwasher. The percolator became a Mr. Coffee became a Keurig. Frozen TV dinners arrived in 1954 and blew people's minds. The microwave oven — military technology repurposed for leftovers — showed up in homes in the late 1970s and changed what “cooking” even meant.

**In the living room:** Three channels became cable (1980s) became satellite (1990s) became streaming (2010s) became *too many choices to count*. The family gathered around *one* television; now everyone has a screen in their pocket. The VCR arrived and you could record a show — revolutionary. Then the DVD. Then the DVR. Then Netflix made all of it obsolete. Vic has lived through every format of recorded entertainment: vinyl records, 8-tracks, cassette tapes, CDs, MP3s, and whatever his grandkids are using now.

**In communication:** The rotary phone (shared, on the wall, don't tie up the line) became the push-button phone became the cordless phone became the cell phone became the smartphone. The answering machine was a miracle — someone could leave a message when you weren't home! Then voicemail. Then text messages. Then FaceTime. Vic's generation went from *waiting for the mail* to *instant video calls with grandchildren 200 miles away*. His email forwards — the ones he curates and sends to his sons every morning — are his version of the letters his grandparents sent from Italy. Same instinct. Different wire.

**In the car:** No seatbelts → seatbelts → airbags → backup cameras → cars that park themselves. Manual everything → power steering → cruise control → GPS navigation. Vic learned to drive on a car you had to *crank*. His grandchildren will learn to drive on cars that drive themselves.

**In school (where Vic spent his career):** Chalkboards → overhead projectors → VCRs in the classroom → computer labs → laptops for every student → AI tutors. Vic was *ahead* of this curve — writing grants for Commodore computers in 1982 when most schools didn't even have a computer room. He saw the future before the district budget caught up.

The man who was born into a world of rotary phones and iceboxes now lives in a world of smartphones and AI. And he adapted to every single transition — not because he's a technologist, but because he's a man who refuses to be left behind.

## 8.3 “Glue Fingers” and the Old Crew

Some identities don't fade. Somewhere in a box or a scrapbook, there's an old newspaper clipping where a young Victor Cicconetti earned the nickname “**Glue Fingers Cicconetti**” — a receiver who didn't drop the ball. Voted **Best Looking in the Class of 1964**. That was high school football in Bayonne, where Friday nights under the lights were the center of the social universe and a good nickname followed you for life.

In his later years, Vic has enjoyed **periodic gatherings with his old high school football buddies** — the guys who blocked for him, ran alongside him, and shared the locker room camaraderie that becomes, decades later, one of the purest forms of friendship a man can have. No pretense. No agenda. Just men who knew each other when they were seventeen and still show up for each other at seventy-nine.

The football brotherhood and the veteran brotherhood overlap in Vic's life — both are groups of men who went through something intense together and never let go of the bond. “Glue Fingers” caught passes in Bayonne. Then he caught wounded soldiers in medevac helicopters. Then he caught students who were falling through the cracks. The hands never stopped reaching.

### **i** Check Our Work — Football

| # | We wrote...                                | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|---|--------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | Vic played high school football in Bayonne |      |       |              |
| 2 | He was nicknamed “Glue Fingers Cicconetti” |      |       |              |
| 3 | He still gathers with old football friends |      |       |              |

**What school? What position? What years? Do you still have the newspaper clipping?**

## 8.4 The Shore Pilgrimage

Even after moving south to Blue Heron Pines in 2020, Vic and Yvonne never let go of the Shore. At 79, they still make the pilgrimage — north on the Parkway to the places where they raised their family, where the kids grew up, where the memories live.

The destinations are always the same, because that's the point:

- **Avon-by-the-Sea** — the quiet beach town with the Victorian boardwalk, where the ocean is the attraction and the crowds stay away. Not Seaside Heights. Not Wildwood. *Avon*. That tells you everything about Vic and Yvonne's taste.
- **Point Pleasant Beach** — the boardwalk, Jenkinson's, the fishing pier, the arcades where the grandkids play the same games the kids played thirty years ago. Shore culture passed down.
- **Pete & Elda's** — the thin-crust pizza institution in Neptune City, open since 1956. Every Shore family has a Pete & Elda's booth that feels like theirs. The Cicconettis' is no different.
- **Kelly's Tavern** — cold drinks, familiar faces, the kind of place where Vic walks in and someone says “hey, Vic.”

And then there was the **family reunion triathlon** — Vic and Yvonne hosted it for **ten great years, every 4th of July**. Not a casual barbecue. A *triathlon*. The whole extended family, competing, laughing, sweating, and celebrating independence the Cicconetti way. Ten consecutive years of organizing an event that brought the family together through competition and cookouts — that's not a hobby, that's a legacy. It's the same man who founded VVA Chapter 151 from scratch and built a technology program at Long Branch: when Vic commits to something, he runs it for a decade.

These aren't restaurants and beaches. They're *landmarks on the map of a life*. The Shark River Hills years (1980–1995), the Wall years (1995–2000), the Neptune years (2000–2020) — decades of Shore living compressed into an afternoon drive and a pizza that tastes like 1985.

That they still make this trip, into their late seventies and now approaching eighty — that’s not nostalgia. That’s identity. The Jersey Shore isn’t where Vic vacations. It’s where Vic *is*.

### Map: The Shore — Then and Now

Four decades of Shore living: Shark River Hills (1980–1995) → Wall (1995–2000) → Neptune (2000–2020) → Blue Heron Pines (2020–present). Plus the landmarks that never change: Pete & Elda’s, Point Pleasant, Avon-by-the-Sea.  
*Interactive map available in the online version.*

### Tell Us a Shore Story

**Everyone:** What’s the definitive Cicconetti Shore story? The beach day that went sideways? The Pete & Elda’s night that turned legendary? The time at Kelly’s that nobody’s allowed to talk about? The boardwalk game somebody FINALLY won after twenty years of trying?  
**Dad & Mom:** Is there a beach, a bench, a spot on the boardwalk that’s *yours*? The place you go when it’s just the two of you?

## 8.5 How Vic Communicates

Victor’s email style is a window into his personality:

| Pattern                              | Example                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Brief subject-as-message</b>      | Subject: “How you doing?” Body: empty                                                                          |
| <b>Emotional milestone responses</b> | “Dearest Son, I hope you can take a long breath and exhale!!!!”                                                |
| <b>The check-in</b>                  | “What’s happening? Did you hear from them? We are going to AC wed & thurs be back Fri pm. Call you later. Dad” |
| <b>Proud grandpa</b>                 | “Look at yourselves!!!!” (with photo, no body text)                                                            |
| <b>Consistent sign-off</b>           | “Love DAD” — every single time                                                                                 |
| <b>Consistent greeting</b>           | “Dearest Son” or “Dearest Greg”                                                                                |

The man who grew up before email, before texting, before social media — he adapted to the digital age on his own terms. Brief. Warm. Consistent. And always ending with love.

### Check Our Work — The Golden Years

| # | We wrote...                                                                                    | TRUE | FALSE | I DON’T KNOW |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | You live at Blue Heron Pines in Egg Harbor City (since 2020); before that, Neptune (2000–2020) |      |       |              |

- 2        You're regulars at  
          Atlantic City
- 3        At 75, Vic asked Greg to  
          order him an air pistol
- 4        After the 75th birthday  
          party, Vic walked  
          around the house  
          laughing

Anything wrong? Fill in what we missed:

### Tell Us a Story

**Dad:** Do you have an Atlantic City system? Be honest — slots, poker, blackjack, craps? What's your biggest win? And what about the one you probably shouldn't tell us about?

**Mom:** What's the thing Dad does in retirement that drives you absolutely crazy? And what's the thing he does that still makes you fall in love with him all over again?

## 8.6 Faith

Vic's faith threads through everything he does. Not the quiet, private kind that stays in the pew. The *Vic* kind — persistent, vocal, and coming at you whether you asked for it or not. G

"The Lord has blessed you once more."

That's how he frames milestones — as blessings, not just achievements. Every email, every phone call, every milestone: *pray about it*. A grandchild's graduation? *The Lord has blessed you*. A new job? *God is good*. A rough patch? *Have you prayed on it?*

Here's the thing: the Cicconetti family stopped going to church decades ago. After Rich finished grammar school, they were done with the monotony of Catholic Mass. The whole family moved on. And then Vic found his Baptist church, did his deep dive into scripture, and came out the other side as the family's **permanent, unsolicited spiritual advisor**.

The joke in the family — and it *is* a joke, told with love — goes like this:

*"Did Dad have a few drinks and corner you to talk about the Bible again?"*

Because that's what happens. A family gathering. A barbecue. A holiday. Vic has a couple of drinks, and suddenly you're getting a one-on-one about prayer, about gratitude, about what the scriptures say about perseverance. He doesn't do it from a pulpit. He does it from a lawn chair, or the kitchen counter, or the driver's seat on the way to Point Pleasant. He persists through resistance. He *always* persists through resistance.

Nobody in the family goes to church anymore. But Vic never stopped being the voice that says: **pray**. Pray when things are good. Pray when things are bad. Pray when you don't feel like it. *Especially* when you don't feel like it.

It's not performative. It's not preachy — well, it's a *little* preachy. But it's real. The man who read the Bible cover to cover, who led youth groups, who joined a Baptist church to challenge himself — that man didn't stop when the formal churchgoing stopped. He just moved the ministry to the dinner table, the phone call, the email forward. His congregation is his family, and his sermons never end. G

The Catholic boy from Bayonne, who married at Assumption Church, who left the monotony of Mass, who walked into a Baptist church, who read the whole book, who now signs his emails with “God bless” and calls his sons to tell them to pray — that man's faith isn't a Sunday habit. It's a Tuesday habit. A Wednesday habit. An every-damn-day habit. And if you're within earshot after he's had a glass of wine? You're going to hear about it.

## 8.7 The Walk-Around-the-House Laugh

After his 75th birthday party in 2021, Vic sent a thank-you email to Greg's family that captures something essential about who he is:

“I am still laughing at your antics on the video. I can be walking around the house and suddenly I think of Greg and Val and man I start smiling then laughing.”

Picture it: Vic, alone in the house, walking from room to room, and suddenly — a memory from the party hits him, and he laughs out loud. Not once, but again and again, days later. This is a man who holds joy close. Who lets the good moments replay. Who walks around his house and laughs at the love of his family.

That image — Vic wandering the house, suddenly breaking into laughter — belongs in any portrait of who this man really is.

### i America's Changing Relationship with Marijuana

**The wide lens:** Few substances trace the arc of American culture as cleanly as marijuana. When Vic was growing up in the 1950s, cannabis was the stuff of *Reefer Madness* propaganda — a Schedule I narcotic lumped with heroin, a moral panic in plant form. By the time he was in Vietnam, it was everywhere among the troops — a coping mechanism for the uncopeable.

- **1970:** Nixon signed the Controlled Substances Act, classifying marijuana as Schedule I — “no accepted medical use, high potential for abuse.” The War on Drugs began.
- **1980s–90s:** Reagan and Clinton escalated enforcement. “Just Say No.” Mandatory minimums. By 1997, nearly **700,000 Americans** were arrested annually for marijuana offenses — more than for all violent crimes combined.
- **1996:** California passed **Proposition 215**, the first medical marijuana law. The dam cracked.
- **2012:** Colorado and Washington became the first states to legalize recreational use.
- **2020:** New Jersey voters approved **Question 1**, legalizing recreational marijuana. Vic's home state.
- **2024:** By now, 24 states plus DC have legalized recreational use. The substance that could get you prison time when Vic was raising his family is now sold in storefronts down the road from his house.

The generation that grew up with “Just Say No” is now the generation buying edibles at a dispensary. The country didn't just change its laws — it changed its entire moral framework around a plant. For a man who has lived through Vietnam, Watergate, the War on Drugs, and legalization — all in one lifetime — the whiplash is its own kind of American experience.

## 8.8 He Won't Back Down

At eighty, Vic is still Vic. He still goes to AC. He still drives to Point Pleasant. He still forwards emails at 6 AM. He still walks around the house laughing at memories of his family. He still signs every message “Love DAD.”

The man who flew medevac missions through combat zones, who walked into a student walkout and led a prayer, who bumped a rifle score by a point to get his kid across the line — that man has never let anything have the last word.

He watched his own father die at fifty-five. He joined a Baptist church to break the cycles he didn't want to repeat. He read the Bible cover to cover. He ran. He pushed everyone around him to be better. And he kept going.

Tom Petty wrote it: *I won't back down*. The Traveling Wilburys sang it: *It's all right, even if you're old and gray*. Sinatra closed every show the same way: *I did it my way*.

Vic lives all three.

At eighty, Vic is still Vic. That's the whole story right there. He's still going to AC. Still driving to Point Pleasant. Still forwarding emails at six in the morning like some kind of Italian-American wire service. Still walking around the house and busting out laughing at something his family did three years ago. Still signing everything “Love DAD.”

The guy who flew medevac through combat zones. Who walked into a student walkout and said “we're praying.” Who bumped a rifle score by a point because that's what fathers do. That guy has never — *never* — let anything have the last word.

He watched his father die at fifty-five. He walked into a Baptist church to break the cycles he saw coming. He read the whole Bible. He ran. He pushed. He kept going.

Tom Petty wrote it: *I won't back down*. Sinatra closed every show the same way: *I did it my way*.

Vic? Vic lives both. Every single day.

### Your Turn — Dad

We wrote this chapter mostly from your emails. But we want the rest of the picture.

- What does a normal Tuesday look like for you?
- Which casino is your casino? Do you have a system?
- Are you still shooting? Still doing target practice?
- What do you watch? What do you read? What music?
- What makes you laugh the hardest?
- What's the thing you do that drives Mom crazy but she secretly loves?

**Mom:** What's the thing *he* does that drives you crazy? And what's the thing about him that still makes you smile after all these years?

**Everyone else:** What's the funniest recent Vic story? The most recent time he made you laugh until you cried?



Figure 8.1: Dad



Figure 8.2: Family event, 2000s



Figure 8.3: The Shore, always the Shore



Figure 8.4: Still going strong



Figure 8.5: Rich & Greg



Figure 8.6: Vic

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*At eighty, Victor Cicconetti is still shopping for air pistols, still going to Atlantic City, still forwarding wisdom to his sons, and still walking around the house laughing at memories of his family. He did it his way. And the best is yet to come.*

Love DAD

## **Part IV**

# **Part IV: Celebration**

## 9 In Their Own Words

*“sshhh its a surprise” — Subject line of Greg’s invitation to the family to contribute tribute messages, February 6, 2026*

### 9.1 A Family Tribute

On February 6, 2026, Greg sent an email with the subject line **“sshhh its a surprise”** to the inner circle: Yvonne, Rich, Kathy Pacifico, AJ, Ellie, Jen, Mike Hurley (both addresses), and Valerie & Frank Elia. The invitation: contribute a message for Dad’s 80th birthday tribute book.

This chapter belongs to the family. Each person who knows and loves Victor has their own story to tell — their own memory, their own moment, their own way of saying what he means to them.

#### ! Add Your Message

**Want to contribute online?** Use the tribute form — type as much or as little as you want. You can even upload a photo.

[Write Your Message for Dad](#)

---

### From Yvonne

#### 💡 Tell Us a Story

**Mom:** What’s the thing about Dad that nobody else sees? The private Vic — the one who exists when it’s just the two of you? What do you want to say to him after almost sixty years together?

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTION] — Yvonne’s message for Victor’s 80th birthday.

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## From Rich

### Tell Us a Story

**Rich:** What's your earliest memory of Dad? The first one, no matter how fuzzy. And what's the thing he taught you — not in a lesson, but just by being him — that you carry with you every day?

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTION] — Rich's message for his father.

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## From Greg

### Tell Us a Story

**Greg:** You've been building this book. You know the facts better than anyone. Now forget the facts — what's the *feeling*? What does "Love DAD" at the end of every email actually mean to you?

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTION] — Greg's message for his father.

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## From the Grandchildren

### Tell Us a Story

**Grandkids:** Don't overthink this. Just answer one question: *What's the thing Grandpa does that always makes you smile?* Maybe it's the way he laughs. Maybe it's something he says every single time. Maybe it's a face he makes. Whatever it is — write it down. Even one sentence is perfect.

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTIONS] — Messages from Victor's three grandchildren: Ellie, Anthony, and Richie.

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## From the Extended Family

Kathy Pacifico, Mike Hurley, Valerie & Frank Elia — and anyone else who wants to share a word.

### Tell Us a Story

**Kathy:** You organized the 75th. What do you know about pulling off a Cicconetti celebration that the rest of us should know? What was the moment from that party that sticks with you?

**Valerie & Frank Elia:** What's your favorite Vic-and-Yvonne story from the Elia side of the family?

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTIONS] — Messages from the extended family.

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## From Fellow Veterans

The brotherhood of VVA Chapter 12 — Leon, David Connelly, Larry Messina, and others from Vic's forward network.

### Tell Us a Story

**Veterans:** Vic doesn't know about this book. Here's your chance to say something about him behind his back — the good kind. What kind of leader was he at Chapter 12? What did the chapter mean to the men who showed up? What's the Vic story you wish everyone knew?

[AWAITING CONTRIBUTIONS] — Messages from fellow veterans and friends.

---

*This chapter will be filled with the voices of the people who know Victor best. Their words will be the heart of this book.*

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## Submit Your Tribute Online

Loading form...

# 10 Happy 80th, Dad

*“An American story.” — Red Bank Register, 1987*

 **Photo Gallery (4 photos)**

## 10.1 A Life Well Lived

As Victor R. Cicconetti turns eighty, the measure of his life is not found in any single achievement — but in the remarkable breadth of what he has given.

**To his country:** Four years of service as an Air Force medic, flying into danger to bring wounded servicemembers home from Vietnam.

**To his students:** Decades of dedication in New Jersey’s public schools, shaping young lives from Long Branch to Asbury Park — the “Man with Many Missions.”

**To his fellow veterans:** A founding voice for Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter 12, ensuring that those who served were never forgotten. Life memberships in the VA and the DAV. A lifetime of showing up.

**To his family:** Nearly sixty years of partnership with Yvonne — his childhood sweetheart, the girl he walked to grammar school in Bayonne. Two sons. Four grandchildren. Ten years of 4th of July family reunion triathlons. A home built on love, food, Italian-American tradition, and the two most important words in his vocabulary: Love DAD.

**To his community:** Entrepreneurship, education, advocacy, and the quiet daily work of being a good neighbor, a good friend, and a good man.

So Victor R. Cicconetti turns eighty. And what do you say about a guy like this? You don’t measure him by one thing. You can’t. The man did too much.

**His country?** Four years in the Air Force. Medic. Flew into combat zones to bring wounded soldiers home from Vietnam. He was eighteen when he signed up. Eighteen.

**His students?** Thirty years in New Jersey’s public schools. Long Branch. Asbury Park. The toughest districts. The kids who needed him most. “Man with Many Missions” — that’s what the newspaper called him. They were right.

**His fellow veterans?** He helped found Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter 12. Life member of the VA. Life member of the DAV. He didn’t just serve and walk away. He kept showing up.

**His family?** Nearly sixty years with Yvonne. The girl he walked to grammar school in Bayonne. Two sons. Four grandchildren. Ten years of 4th of July family triathlons. And every email, every phone call, every single message ends the same way: Love DAD.

**His community?** The restaurant. The schools. The veterans' hall. The quiet daily work of being a good man in a world that doesn't always make that easy.

## 10.2 The Story So Far

Victor's story is — as a New Jersey newspaper once wrote — “an American story.” It is the story of Italian immigrants who left the mountains of Abruzzo for the streets of Bayonne. It is the story of Bayonne High's Best Looking, Class of 1964, who answered his country's call at eighteen and flew medevac missions through the Tet Offensive. It is the story of a veteran who came home and built a career helping young people. It is the story of a husband, a father, and a grandfather who signs every email with love.

From Collepietro to Bayonne. From the Air Force to the classroom. From the classroom to the restaurant to the VVA hall. From one generation to the next — and the next — and the next.

### One Last Story

**Everyone:** If you could describe Vic in exactly three words — just three — what would they be? And one more: What's the thing about Victor Cicconetti that you want his great-grandchildren to know someday?

## 10.3 How This Book Was Made

Dad, you might be wondering: *how did they put all this together?*

Here's the short version: **Greg sat at his computer and told stories about you.** That's really it. He talked about growing up in Shark River Hills, about your career at Long Branch, about the restaurant, the parades, the Baptist church, the Shore trips, the emails you send at 6 AM. Everything he remembered. Everything the family remembers.

But he didn't type the book himself. He had help from a new kind of tool — an **artificial intelligence assistant** called **Claude**. Think of it like this: if Greg hired a really good writer to help him organize his thoughts, that's basically what happened. Except the writer lives inside the computer.

Here's how the process worked:

Greg tells family  
stories\n(your son, at his  
computer)

Claude listens and  
organizes\n(the AI writing  
assistant)

Draft chapters  
written\n(10 chapters +  
appendices)

Greg reviews every  
word\n(nothing goes in  
without his OK)

**In plain English:**

1. **Greg talked.** He sat down over several sessions and told the story of your life — the parts he knows, the parts the family knows, the parts that come from your emails and photos and the stories you’ve told a hundred times at the dinner table.
2. **The computer organized it.** Claude took those stories and arranged them into chapters, added historical context (what was happening in the country during each era of your life), found the right music for each era, and made it look nice on the screen.
3. **Greg checked everything.** Every single fact, every story, every detail — Greg read it and either approved it, corrected it, or said “that’s not right, here’s what really happened.” The AI doesn’t know your life — *Greg does*. Claude is the pen. Greg is the author.
4. **The family fills in the gaps.** That’s what those “Check Our Work” boxes are for — so you, Mom, Rich, Ellie, Anthony, and Richie can tell us what we got right, what we got wrong, and what stories we’re missing.
5. **It became this website.** The book you’re reading is a website that works on your computer, your phone, or a tablet. It’s not printed (yet — we might make a printed version too). The music links play real songs. The photos are from the family collection.

**What Greg actually did:** He’s the architect of this whole thing. He decided what the book should be. He chose the structure. He told the stories. He picked the music. He reviewed every word. He’s the one who knows that “Glue Fingers” was your football nickname and that you shook O.J.’s hand in AC and that you read the Bible cover to cover. The AI doesn’t know any of that — it only knows what Greg tells it.

**What the AI did:** It’s a tool, like a very sophisticated typewriter. It helped organize, it helped write, it helped research the historical context (what year the Berlin Wall fell, when the first microwave came out, how many Italians came through Ellis Island). It’s fast, it’s thorough, and it doesn’t get tired. But it can’t tell a single Cicconetti story without Greg putting it in.

**Think of it this way:** You wrote grants to get computers into the classroom in 1982 because you believed technology could help students learn better. Forty-four years later, your son is using the grandchild of those computers to write a book about your life. The apple doesn’t fall far from the tree, Dad. You started this.

## 10.4 Still Going

At eighty, Vic is still shopping for air pistols. Still going to AC. Still forwarding life wisdom to his sons. Still walking around the house and suddenly breaking into laughter at the memory of his family’s antics.

Still the same man from Bayonne who answered the call. G He won’t back down. He did it his way. And he’s not done.

At eighty — eighty — Vic is still shopping for air pistols online. Still hitting AC. Still sending those emails at six in the morning. Still walking around the house and cracking himself up about something his family did years ago.

Still the same kid from Bayonne. G He won’t back down. He did it his way. And if you think he’s done? You don’t know Vic Cicconetti.



Figure 10.1: The family, September 2017



Figure 10.2: Vic

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Happy 80th birthday, Dad.

*The best is yet to come.*

Happy 80th, Dad. From Collepietro to Bayonne to Lackland to Thailand to Long Branch to the Shore to right here, right now.

*And the best? The best is yet to come.*

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Love, Your Family

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*Prepared with love by the Cicconetti family, March 2026.*

# Life Timeline

## Victor R. Cicconetti — Eighty Years

*i*

Soundtrack: Reelin’ in the Years

- Steely Dan — “Reelin’ in the Years”

Table 1: Victor R. Cicconetti — Life Timeline

| Year           | Event                                                                   | TRUE | FALSE | I DON’T KNOW |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| March 29, 1946 | Born at 10th St & Ave C, Manhattan;                                     |      |       |              |
| ~1947          | family moves to Bayonne ~age 10                                         |      |       |              |
|                | Brother Denis born ~18 months later;                                    |      |       |              |
|                | inseparable as boys                                                     |      |       |              |
| Late 1950s     | Walks young Yvonne to grammar school before heading to Bayonne High     |      |       |              |
| Early 1960s    | Football star at Bayonne HS — “Glue Fingers Cicconetti”;                |      |       |              |
|                | works at Elbaum’s deli                                                  |      |       |              |
| 1964           | Graduates BHS, Class of 1964 — Voted Best Looking; enlists in Air Force |      |       |              |
| 1966–1967      | Stationed at Barksdale AFB, Shreveport, LA                              |      |       |              |

| Year         | Event                                                                             | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| Aug 20, 1967 | Marries Yvonne C. Elia at Assumption Church, Bayonne — he's 21, she's 19          |      |       |              |
| 1968         | Deployed to U-Tapao RTAFB, Thailand; medical air evacuations during Tet Offensive |      |       |              |
| 1969         | Honorable discharge; first married home at 84 Humphrey's Ave, Bayonne             |      |       |              |
| ~1970        | Enrolls at St. Peter's College; works as roofer, plumber, tutor                   |      |       |              |
| ~1971        | Brief move to San Diego; returns to Bayonne                                       |      |       |              |
| Oct 1, 1974  | Son Greg born AND signs first teaching contract at Bayonne HS — same day          |      |       |              |
| Aug 27, 1977 | Son Richard born; buy first home on Avenue E, Bayonne                             |      |       |              |
| 1980         | Father Victor Sr. dies (~55); family moves to 104 Highland Ave, Shark River Hills |      |       |              |
| ~1982        | Writes grants for Commodore computers at Long Branch HS                           |      |       |              |

| Year        | Event                                                                                  | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1987        | <i>Red Bank Register</i> profile: “Man with Many Missions”                             |      |       |              |
| 1989        | Dept head of Business Education, Long Branch HS; first technology program for district |      |       |              |
| April 1992  | Leads Long Branch students in prayer after Rodney King walkout; photo in APPress       |      |       |              |
| 1995        | Builds “5 bedroom, 5 bath palace” at Rue de la Porte, Wall, NJ                         |      |       |              |
| ~1990s      | Assistant Principal at Asbury Park High School                                         |      |       |              |
| 1997        | Mother Eleanor passes away                                                             |      |       |              |
| ~1990s      | Co-founds Bistro-by-the-Sea with Yvonne and Rich                                       |      |       |              |
| ~1990s      | Hosts 4th of July family reunion triathlons (10 consecutive years)                     |      |       |              |
| ~2000       | Retires from school administration; moves to 18 Waterview Ct, Neptune                  |      |       |              |
| Oct 2, 2004 | Granddaughter Ellie born                                                               |      |       |              |
| 2005        | Yvonne retires from teaching                                                           |      |       |              |

| Year           | Event                                                           | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 2007           | 40th wedding anniversary;<br>APPress feature                    |      |       |              |
| July 25, 2009  | Grandson Anthony born                                           |      |       |              |
| 2009           | Brother Michael C. Cicconetti passes away                       |      |       |              |
| July 20, 2011  | Grandson Richie Jr. born                                        |      |       |              |
| Oct 2012       | Superstorm Sandy hits the Shore;<br>Waterview Ct in flood zone  |      |       |              |
| 2018           | Rich marries Sharon; Greg promoted to Research Fellow           |      |       |              |
| 2020           | Moves to Blue Heron Pines, Egg Harbor City; “play golf forever” |      |       |              |
| March 2021     | 75th birthday celebration with tribute video                    |      |       |              |
| ~2025          | Sister Loretta Keating passes away                              |      |       |              |
| March 29, 2026 | <b>Turns 80 — this celebration</b>                              |      |       |              |



#### Check our work — Timeline:

*(Any dates wrong? Any approximate dates you know exactly? Any major life events we missed entirely?)*

## Undated Events

The following milestones are confirmed but we don't know when they happened. Can you fill in the years?

| Event                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Year? | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|------|-------|--------------|
| Victor founds<br>VVA Chapter<br>151 in Asbury<br>Park; serves as<br>president<br>Victor becomes<br>life member of<br>VA and DAV<br>Vic reads the<br>Bible cover to<br>cover; leads<br>Christian<br>Crusaders youth<br>group |       |      |       |              |

### Tell Us a Story

**Everyone:** Look at this timeline. What's the biggest thing missing? The event that should be on this list but isn't? Don't think about it too hard — just name the first thing that comes to mind.

**Dad:** What year would you say was the best year of your life? And what year was the hardest?

# Life Journey Map

From a Manhattan tenement to the Jersey Shore to a golf community in the Pines — eighty years of addresses, on one map.

*The interactive Life Journey Map is available in the online version of this book. It traces Victor's 21 addresses from 10th St & Avenue C in Manhattan (1946) through 671 Cypress Point Drive at Blue Heron Pines (2020–present), with animated fly-through and era-colored markers.*

## Help Us Fill In the Gaps

**Dad & Mom:** We have the addresses but not always the stories. Pick any pin on the map and tell us what you remember about living there. What did the house look like? Who were the neighbors? What was happening in your life at that address?

**Anyone:** Do you remember visiting Vic and Yvonne at any of these addresses? What's the memory?

# Family Tree

The Cicconetti family spans four generations — from Victor Sr. and Eleanor in Bayonne to grandchildren carrying the legacy forward today.

## Generation 1: The Parents

Victor Cicconetti Sr. (1925–1980)      m.      Eleanor Salone (d. 1997)

Frank Elia (d. ~1962)      m.      Mary Chiarolanza (b. ~1920, Italy)

## Generation 2: The Cicconetti Six & the Elia Sisters

Victor Sr. and Eleanor had six children. Birth order per Yvonne:

Table 3: The Cicconetti Six

| # | Name                          | Status                   | Spouse                               | Children               | Notes                                                     |
|---|-------------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Victor R. Cicconetti</b>   | Living (b. Mar 29, 1946) | Yvonne (nee Elia)                    | Greg, Richard          | The birthday honoree                                      |
| 2 | Dennis Cicconetti             | Deceased (pre-2009)      | —                                    | Dawn, Dana, Lisa       | Brother; born ~18 months after Vic; “inseparable” as boys |
| 3 | Rev. Leanora “Lee” Cicconetti | Living (~67)             | 1st: John Vito (div.); 2nd: Clavelli | Three sons (names TBD) | Sister; reverend; genealogist; “took over their chores”   |
| 4 | Robert “Bob” Cicconetti       | Living                   | Ret. Lt. Col. Elizabeth              | Malia, Robert Jr.      | Brother; “the handy man”                                  |
| 5 | Loretta Keating               | Deceased (~2025)         | Louis Keating Sr.                    | Louie, Joey, Tommy     | Sister                                                    |
| 6 | Michael C. Cicconetti         | Deceased (2009)          | Karen Haraksin (deceased)            | Michael                | Youngest brother                                          |

## Yvonne’s Side: The Elia / Chiarolanza Family

Mary Chiarolanza was one of five sisters who emigrated from Italy. The **Chiarolanza sisters** (oldest to youngest):

Table 4: The Chiarolanza Sisters

| Name                   | Spouse                | Children / Notes                                                                       |
|------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rosie                  | Walter Sr.            | Son: Walter Jr. (“Juno” — Rosie couldn’t pronounce “Junior”)                           |
| Carnie                 | —                     | Details TBD                                                                            |
| Margie                 | —                     | Oldest child: Frank (m. Lena; sons “Vinny” James Elliott & “Cheech” Frank Elliott Jr.) |
| Linda                  | —                     | Details TBD                                                                            |
| Mary (Yvonne’s mother) | Frank Elia (d. ~1962) | Yvonne, Mary Ann                                                                       |

Table 5: The Elia Sisters

| Name                          | Status | Spouse                                      | Children                                                                                            | Notes                                                   |
|-------------------------------|--------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Yvonne Cicconetti</b>      | Living | Victor R. Cicconetti                        | Greg, Richard                                                                                       | nee Elia                                                |
| Mary Ann “Auntie Buff” Hurley | Living | Michael Hurley Sr. (Ret. Capt., Bayonne PD) | Kathy (m. Pete; sons Christian & Jet), Michael (daughter Kiara w/ Jody; daughter Michaela w/ Maria) | Lives across the street from Vic & Yvonne in Egg Harbor |

### Generation 3: Victor & Yvonne’s Children

Table 6: Generation 3 — Victor and Yvonne’s Two Sons

| Name                             | Born            | Spouse                                                            | Notes                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Greg Cicconetti</b>           | October 1, 1974 | 1st: Jennifer Feulmer (b. May 23, 1976); 2nd: Valerie (div. 2025) | Ph.D., Research Fellow; father of Ellie and Anthony (with Jennifer)                        |
| <b>Richard Victor Cicconetti</b> | August 27, 1977 | Sharon K. Doughty (m. 2018)                                       | Rutgers; Cicco Devel; co-founded Bistro-by-the-Sea; father of Richie; stepfather to Jessie |

### Generation 4: The Grandchildren

Victor and Yvonne have **three biological grandchildren** and two they embraced as family:

Table 7: Generation 4 — The Grandchildren

| Name                                            | Born            | Parent                      | Notes                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Jessie Leeks                                    | June 4, 1994    | Sharon (prior relationship) | Rich’s stepdaughter                                 |
| <b>Ellie Wexler</b>                             | October 2, 2004 | Greg & Jennifer             | Also known as Natalie Cicconetti / Ellie Cicconetti |
| <b>Anthony John Cicconetti</b>                  | July 25, 2009   | Greg & Jennifer             |                                                     |
| <b>Richard Victor Cicconetti Jr. (“Richie”)</b> | July 20, 2011   | Rich & Sharon               | Currently a high school sophomore (2026)            |

Vic also embraced **Hunter** and **Noah** — twin sons of Greg’s second wife Valerie from her first marriage — as his own grandchildren. At the 75th birthday in 2021, all five were part of the celebration.

## Victor’s Career Timeline

Table 8: Career milestones (per Yvonne, Feb 2026)

| Year        | Role                         | Notes                                                                                                 |
|-------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ~1960–64    | Bayonne High School          | Football star (“Glue Fingers Cicconetti”); Voted Best Looking, Class of 1964; worked at Elbaum’s deli |
| 1964–68     | U.S. Air Force               | 4 years; served in Thailand during Tet Offensive (1968)                                               |
| ~1968–74    | St. Peter’s College          | Worked as roofer, plumber, tutor to pay his way                                                       |
| Oct 1, 1974 | Bayonne High School          | Signed first teaching contract — same day Greg was born                                               |
| 1989        | Long Branch High School      | Dept. head of Business Education; developed first technology program for the district                 |
| —           | Asbury Park High School      | Assistant Principal                                                                                   |
| —           | VVA Chapter 151, Asbury Park | Founder & President; organized all aspects and outreach                                               |
| ~2020       | Retired                      | Moved to Blue Heron Pines to “play golf forever”                                                      |

## Legend

| Style       | Meaning |
|-------------|---------|
| <b>Bold</b> | Living  |

| Style            | Meaning                        |
|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Noted “Deceased” | Deceased                       |
| “TBD”            | Name/details not yet confirmed |

Visual Family Tree

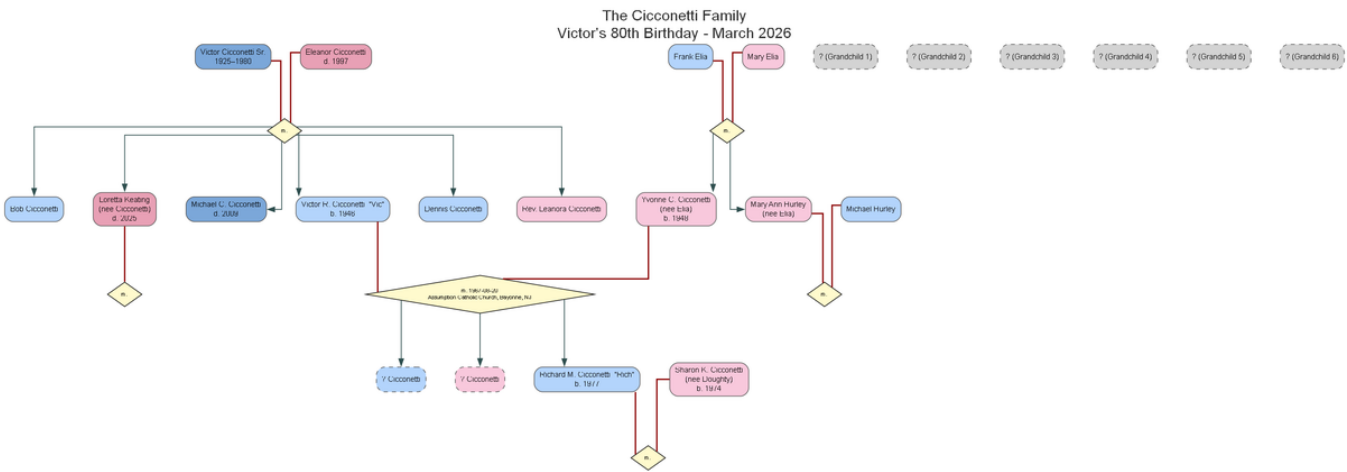


Figure 3: The Cicconetti Family Tree — dashed borders indicate names we still need.

Note

**Updated March 2026** with corrections from Yvonne’s text messages (Feb 20, 2026) and Greg’s notes. Grandchildren birth dates corrected. Extended family (Chiarolanza sisters, cousins) and career timeline added. See [sources/mom-texts-transcription.md](#) for source material.

# Correct the Record

*Dad, Mom — we did our homework. We dug through newspapers, public records, census data, and old emails. We’re pretty sure we got most of it right. But this is YOUR story, not ours. So here’s everything we think we know. Tell us where we nailed it, where we blew it, and what we missed entirely.*

## How This Works

We’ve listed every factual claim in this book. For each one, just pick one:

|                     | Meaning                   |
|---------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>TRUE</b>         | Yes, that’s right         |
| <b>FALSE</b>        | No, that’s wrong          |
| <b>I DON’T KNOW</b> | Not sure / don’t remember |

After each section, there’s a space to set the record straight — correct what we got wrong, fill in what we missed, or just tell us more.

**!** Respond Online

**Prefer to fill this out on your phone or computer?** Use the online form — it takes about 10 minutes and your answers go straight to Greg.

[Open the Fact-Check Form](#)

## Chapter 1: Two Families, One City

### The Cicconetti Side

| # | We wrote...                                               | TRUE | FALSE | I DON’T KNOW |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 1 | The Cicconetti name traces to Collepietro, Abruzzo, Italy |      |       |              |
| 2 | The name means “little Cicco,” from Franciscus            |      |       |              |
| 3 | The family has been in Collepietro since at least 1778    |      |       |              |

| #  | We wrote...                                                           | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 4  | Victor Sr. was born in Bayonne in 1925                                |      |       |              |
| 5  | Victor Sr. married Eleanor Salone                                     |      |       |              |
| 6  | Eleanor was one of three Salone sisters: Marge, Eleanor, Josie        |      |       |              |
| 7  | The Salone sisters grew up on the Lower East Side of Manhattan        |      |       |              |
| 8  | During the Depression, the sisters spent time in an orphanage         |      |       |              |
| 9  | Their mother Anna worked as a sweatshop seamstress                    |      |       |              |
| 10 | Victor Sr. and Eleanor raised six children in Bayonne                 |      |       |              |
| 11 | The six children were: Victor, Dennis, Leanora, Bob, Loretta, Michael |      |       |              |
| 12 | Victor Sr. died in 1980                                               |      |       |              |
| 13 | Eleanor died in 1997                                                  |      |       |              |

**i Set the record straight — The Cicconetti Side:**  
*(What did we get wrong? What did we miss? Tell us anything about the Cicconetti family history.)*

### The Elia / Chiarolanza Side

| #  | We wrote...                                                                      | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 14 | Yvonne's mother Mary's maiden name was Chiarolanza (family spelling: Chirolanza) |      |       |              |
| 15 | The Chiarolanza family came from Campania, likely Montecorvino Rovella           |      |       |              |

| #  | We wrote...                                                                                        | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 16 | The 1940 Census shows Mary (age 20) in Bayonne with father Alfonso, mother Angelina, and 4 sisters |      |       |              |
| 17 | Mary worked as a seamstress at the Maidenform factory, 154 Avenue E                                |      |       |              |
| 18 | Frank Elia worked as a poultry processor                                                           |      |       |              |
| 19 | Frank died around 1962, when Yvonne was about 14                                                   |      |       |              |
| 20 | After Frank's death, Mary married Anthony Galella                                                  |      |       |              |
| 21 | Greg named his son Anthony after Anthony Galella                                                   |      |       |              |

**i Set the record straight — The Elia / Chiarolanza Side:**  
*(What did we get wrong? What did we miss? Tell us anything about Mom's family.)*

## Chapter 2: Two Paths

### Victor's Military Service

| #  | We wrote...                                       | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|---------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 22 | Victor joined the Air Force in 1965 at age 19     |      |       |              |
| 23 | He served as a medic                              |      |       |              |
| 24 | He flew medical air evacuations in Southeast Asia |      |       |              |
| 25 | His service ended in 1969                         |      |       |              |
| 26 | "MedFlyBoy" was his nickname from service         |      |       |              |

**i Set the record straight — Victor's Military Service:**  
*(Bases, units, buddies, stories — anything you can tell us about those years.)*

## Yvonne's Early Life

| #  | We wrote...                                    | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 27 | Yvonne was born approximately April 1948       |      |       |              |
| 28 | She grew up in Bayonne                         |      |       |              |
| 29 | Losing her father at ~14 shaped her resilience |      |       |              |
| 30 | Her sister Mary Ann was her closest bond       |      |       |              |

**i** Set the record straight — Yvonne's Early Life:  
(Mom, what do you remember about growing up? Where did you go to school? What were you like as a kid?)

## Chapter 3: August 20, 1967

| #  | We wrote...                                            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 31 | Victor and Yvonne married on August 20, 1967           |      |       |              |
| 32 | The wedding was at Assumption Catholic Church, Bayonne |      |       |              |
| 33 | Victor was 21, Yvonne was 19                           |      |       |              |
| 34 | Victor was still in the Air Force when they married    |      |       |              |

**i** Set the record straight — The Wedding:  
(How did you two meet? Who introduced you? What do you remember about the wedding day?)

## Chapter 4: Man with Many Missions

| #  | We wrote...                                                         | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 35 | Victor was an administrator at Long Branch High School in the 1980s |      |       |              |

| #  | We wrote...                                                              | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 36 | The Red Bank Register profiled him in 1987 as “Man with Many Missions”   |      |       |              |
| 37 | He also worked in the Asbury Park school district                        |      |       |              |
| 38 | He retired from education in 2000                                        |      |       |              |
| 39 | Yvonne taught health in Jersey City public schools                       |      |       |              |
| 40 | Yvonne retired in 2005                                                   |      |       |              |
| 41 | Yvonne then served as Allied Health Vocational advisor for Hudson County |      |       |              |

**i Set the record straight — Careers:**

*(What were the schools like? Favorite students? Best stories from the classroom? The “Man with Many Missions” article — do you still have a copy?)*

## Chapter 5: The Family Table

| #  | We wrote...                                                                     | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 42 | Victor, Yvonne, and Richard co-founded Bistro-by-the-Sea in Avon-by-the-Sea, NJ |      |       |              |
| 43 | Mary Ann Hurley ran a pizza bistro in Bayonne                                   |      |       |              |

**! This section is almost empty without you!**

*(What was the restaurant called? Where was it? What years? Which son? What were the signature dishes? What was it like running a restaurant as a family? How about Mary Ann’s pizza bistro?)*

## Chapter 6: Serving Those Who Served

| #  | We wrote...                                                          | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 44 | Victor was a founding member of VVA Chapter 12 in Ocean Township, NJ |      |       |              |
| 45 | He served as president of Chapter 12                                 |      |       |              |
| 46 | He is a life member of the VA                                        |      |       |              |
| 47 | He is a life member of the DAV                                       |      |       |              |

**i** **Set the record straight — Veterans Advocacy:**  
*(When was Chapter 12 founded? Is it still active? Who were the other founders? What did the chapter do for veterans in the community?)*

## Chapter 7: Family Man

| #  | We wrote...                                                                                            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 48 | Victor and Yvonne have two sons: Greg and Richard Victor                                               |      |       |              |
| 49 | Rich was born approximately August 1977                                                                |      |       |              |
| 50 | Rich attended Rutgers University                                                                       |      |       |              |
| 51 | Rich married Sharon K. Doughty                                                                         |      |       |              |
| 52 | They have three biological grandchildren: Ellie Wexler, Anthony John Cicconetti, Richie Cicconetti Jr. |      |       |              |
| 53 | Ellie and Anthony are Greg's children; Richie is Rich's son                                            |      |       |              |

**i** **Corrected February 2026** by Anthony Cicconetti. Previously listed as “three children, six grandchildren” — corrected to two sons and three biological grandchildren.

## Chapter 8: “Love DAD”

| #  | We wrote...                                                                     | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 54 | Victor and Yvonne live in Egg Harbor City / Galloway Township area              |      |       |              |
| 55 | They are regulars at Atlantic City                                              |      |       |              |
| 56 | At 75, Vic asked Greg to order him an air pistol for target practice            |      |       |              |
| 57 | After the 75th birthday party, Vic walked around the house laughing at memories |      |       |              |
| 58 | Vic signs every email “Love DAD”                                                |      |       |              |
| 59 | Vic greets Greg as “Dearest Son” or “Dearest Greg”                              |      |       |              |

**i** **Set the record straight — The Golden Years:**  
(What’s daily life like now? Favorite AC casino? Any hobbies we missed? What makes Dad laugh?)

## The Timeline

| #  | We wrote...                  | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|------------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 60 | Born March 29, 1946, Bayonne |      |       |              |
| 61 | Air Force 1965–1969          |      |       |              |
| 62 | Married August 20, 1967      |      |       |              |
| 63 | Long Branch HS, 1980s        |      |       |              |
| 64 | Red Bank Register, 1987      |      |       |              |
| 65 | Retired from education, 2000 |      |       |              |

| #  | We wrote...            | TRUE | FALSE | I DON'T KNOW |
|----|------------------------|------|-------|--------------|
| 66 | 40th anniversary, 2007 |      |       |              |
| 67 | Turning 80, March 2026 |      |       |              |

**i** **Set the record straight — Timeline:**  
*(Any dates wrong? Any major milestones we missed entirely?)*

## What We Know We're Missing

These are the biggest gaps. If you know the answers, this is where you'll make the biggest difference:

1. ~~Victor's exact birthday~~ — **RESOLVED:** March 29, 1946
2. ~~Names of all children~~ — **RESOLVED:** Two sons: Greg and Richard Victor Cicconetti
3. ~~Names of all grandchildren~~ — **RESOLVED:** Three: Ellie Wexler, Anthony John Cicconetti, Richard Victor Cicconetti Jr.
4. **The restaurant** — name, location, years, which son
5. **VVA Chapter 12** — founding year
6. **Where Victor served in Vietnam** — specific bases or locations
7. **How Victor and Yvonne met** — courtship story
8. **What the grandkids call him** — Pop-Pop? Grandpa? Something else?

*This isn't a test. There are no wrong answers. The whole point is to get YOUR version of the story — because your version is the real one. We just wrote the first draft.*

## Submit Your Corrections Online

Loading form...